

World as (Arabic) Text: Mīr Dāmād and the Neopythagoreanization of Philosophy in Safavid Iran

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Abstract

The heavily Neoplatonic and antiquarian-perennialist tenor of Safavid philosophy is now widely recognized by specialists; but few have acknowledged its equally notable *Neopythagorean* turn. Likewise, that the primary mode of applied Neoplatonic-Neopythagorean philosophy as a Safavid imperial way of life was *occult science* has been ignored altogether, making impossible a history of its practice. The case of the Twelver Shi'i sage-mage Mīr Dāmād – famed down to the present as an occult scientist – is here especially illustrative: for he was largely responsible for this Neopythagoreanization of Safavid philosophy, which saw the remarkable transmutation of Ibn Sīnā himself into a Neopythagorean-occultist, by his espousal of a peculiarly Mamluk-Timurid-Aqquyunlu brand of philosophical *lettrism* (*ilm al-ḥurūf*) in at least three of his many works. The example of this imperial Neopythagoreanizing lettrist is thus crucial for understanding the intellectual and religiopolitical continuity of Safavid Shi'i culture with Sunni precedent, as well as contemporary Persianate and Latinate parallels. Within Western history of science more broadly, Mīr Dāmād and the host of his fellow Muslim kabbalists must now be restored to the master *mathesis* narrative whereby scientific modernity is but the upshot of early modern Western philosophers' penchant for *reading the world as a mathematical text*.

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Keywords

Mīr Dāmād – Safavid philosophy – Neopythagoreanism – Neoplatonism – occultism – lettrism – kabbalah – *mathesis* – history of science

Résumé

Les ténors néoplatoniciens et pérennialistes antiquaires de la philosophie safavide sont aujourd'hui largement reconnu par les spécialistes ; mais peu ont admis son tour-nant néopythagorien tout aussi remarquable. De même que le mode principal de la philosophie néoplatonicienne-néopythagoricienne, en tant que mode de vie impérial safavide, soit la science occulte a été complètement ignoré, rendant impossible une histoire de sa pratique. Le cas du sage-mage shi'ite duodécimain Mīr Dāmād – connu jusqu'à présent comme un scientifique occulte – est ici particulièrement illustratif, car il est en grande partie responsable de cette néopythagorisation de la philosophie sa-favide – qui est allée jusqu'à la transmogrification d'Ibn Sīnā lui-même en occultiste néopythagorien – par son adhésion à une marque particulière de lettrisme philo-sophique mamelouk-timouride-aqquyunlu (*'ilm al-ḥurūf*) dans au moins trois de ses nombreuses œuvres. L'exemple de ce lettriste néopythagorien impérial est donc crucial pour comprendre la continuité intellectuelle et religio-politique de la culture shi'ite safavide avec un précédent sunnite, ainsi que les parallèles persans et latins contemporains. De façon plus générale, Mīr Dāmād et le noyau de ses confrères kabbal-istes musulmans doivent maintenant être restitués au récit de la *mathesis* qui a fait que la modernité scientifique n'est rien d'autre que le résultat du penchant des premiers philosophes occidentaux modernes à lire le monde comme un texte mathématique.

Mots-clés

Mīr Dāmād – philosophie safavide – néopythagorisme – néoplatonisme – occultisme – lettrisme – kabbalah – *mathesis* – histoire des sciences

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a wise and letters play of all you can ceive

JAMES JOYCE, *Finnegans Wake*

• • •

My service to You may be poor
 but Your grace toward me is limitless:
 it has rendered Avicennan riddles
 but an *ABC* to my science.

MĪR DĀMĀD, *Dīwān-i Ishrāq*¹



Introduction: Islamic Philosophy as Occult-Scientific Practice

In recent decades, and watered by the labors of Henry Corbin in particular, the study of Safavid philosophy has emerged as a fertile subfield in its own right; it is routinely identified by specialists and nonspecialists alike as the early modern culmination of Islamicate metaphysical thought in its grand synthesis of all preceding philosophical, theological and mystical currents – Avicennan, Illuminationist, Sufi, Sunni, Shi‘i.² We now have a general picture of the intellectual and religious commitments of the most prominent Safavid philosophers, including in the first place Mullā Ṣadrā Shīrāzī (d. 1045/1635) and his teachers, and their crucial role in the creation of a new Safavid imperial Twelver Shi‘i culture is universally acknowledged.³ We understand that the central focus of many Safavid thinkers is Neoplatonic *theosis* (*ta‘alluh*), aka *theomimesis* or *homoiosis theo* (*tashabbuh bi-l-bārī*), a concept signaling adherence to a specific set of ascetic-mystical practices aimed at purifying the mind and body and preparing them for transcendence.⁴ But the history of the *practice* of Safavid philosophy has yet to be written; quite simply, we have little

1 P. 81, quatrain 5: *har chand ṭarīq-i khidmat-i mā bad buwad / ilṭāf-i tū andar ḥaqq-i mā bī-ḥadd buwad // az lutf-i tū mushkil-i Ishārāt u Shifā / dar maktab-i ‘ilm-i mā yakī abjad buwad*.

2 See e.g. Corbin, *En islam iranien*, 4:9–201; idem, *La philosophie iranienne islamique*. Naturally, individual scholars have emphasized certain of these elements over others according to personal taste and training; Sajjad Rizvi identifies, for instance, four distinct approaches to Mullā Ṣadrā: esotericist, comparativist, Avicennist and Iranian nativist (*Mullā Ṣadrā and Metaphysics*, 6–14).

3 The exceptional status of Mullā Ṣadrā in this context is argued for in Jambet, *La fin de toute chose*; my thanks to Mathieu Terrier for this reference.

4 Rizvi, *Mullā Ṣadrā and Metaphysics*, 24–26.

idea how its exponents lived their systems, how they helped construct this new society.⁵

While our ignorance in this respect is a problem besetting the study of Islamicate philosophy in general, it is especially hobbling with respect to its Safavid subset. For the tenor of Safavid philosophy is strongly *Neoplatonic* in most respects, as is widely recognized;⁶ less recognized is the fact that, in practical and indeed political terms, this often entailed an embrace of the Neoplatonic notion of sage (*ḥakīm*) as *occultist architect of the world*, theurgic invoker of the celestial and the divine through practices expressly magical in order to understand – and shape – reality. That is to say, an investment in the occult sciences (*al-ʿulūm al-gharība*) was not only considered unproblematic by the majority of Safavid scholarly elites, but in fact indispensable to the practice of Neoplatonic philosophy.⁷ (Mullā Ṣadrā, whose oeuvre has little explicitly occult-scientific content, would here seem to be an exception.) This point has long been appreciated by specialists of late antique or Renaissance Neoplatonism;⁸ but persistent scholarly positivism and occultophobia on the one hand and the Corbinian religionist insistence on disappearing occultism into the uselessly flabby and expressly apolitical categories of “mysticism” and “esotericism” on the other means that this basic aspect of philosophical practice in Safavid Iran has yet to be acknowledged, much less studied – for all that it is a *sine qua non* to any understanding of spiritual-metaphysical and political-legal authority as two sides of the same Safavid imperial coin.⁹

5 Rizvi, “Philosophy as a Way of Life,” 44. I extend here Rizvi’s application of the work of Pierre Hadot (d. 2010) to the history of Islamic philosophy, and particularly his *Philosophy as a Way of Life*.

6 On this Neoplatonic turn see Pourjavady and Schmidtke, “An Eastern Renaissance?”; Rizvi, “(Neo)Platonism Revived.”

7 This sociological rubric, designating those natural, mathematical and/or religious sciences the mastery of which is relatively rare – i.e., elite sciences –, includes astrology, alchemy and variety of magical and divinatory techniques; they are routinely flagged as such in encyclopedias of the sciences, biographical dictionaries, chronicles, legal tracts, etc. Less frequently used terms in Persian are *ʿulūm khafīyya* or *ghāmiḍa*, sciences that are hidden or occult, referring rather to their epistemological remit, as sciences in which one must extrapolate from visible (*ẓāhir*) data to invisible (*bāṭin*). Its 19th-century European flavor notwithstanding, the term occultism is here used simply to denote to a scholarly investment in one or more of the occult sciences.

8 See e.g. Marx-Wolf, “Pythagoras the Theurgist”; Shaw, “Eros and Arithmos”; Clucas, “Angelic Conversations.”

9 On this theme see Melvin-Koushki, *The Occult Science of Empire*; idem, “Powers of One”; idem, “Is (Islamic) Occult Science Science?”; Jambet, *Le gouvernement divin*. To be fair, such an antihistorical elision does not seem to have been the intent of Corbin himself; but his

The equally strong *Neopythagorean* tenor of Safavid philosophy is also routinely elided in the literature, and for similar reasons.¹⁰ Here again, it is well known among specialists that Neopythagoreanism as a distinct late antique philosophical current was effectively fused with Neoplatonism from Plotinus and Iamblichus onward (to the everlasting annoyance of Aristotelians). As such, the great resurgence of Neoplatonic-Neopythagorean-occultist thought in 15th-17th-century Europe known as the Renaissance featured the lionization of Pythagoras, father of *philosophia* itself, as preeminent model of *sage-as-mage*, (occult) scientist and mystic in equal measure.¹¹ The (Neo)pythagorean cosmogonic doctrine positing number as the first and most fundamental principle of the universe, the intellect's only vehicle of return to the One, accordingly became foundational to early modern European philosophy-science. This prompted in turn to the celebrated *mathematization of the cosmos*, a quest associated with the holy lineage *Copernicus-Kepler-Galileo-Newton*, and culminating with the latter's *Principia Mathematica*, universally hailed as the basis for "scientific modernity" (the *mathesis* narrative).

Yet Pythagoras was lionized in precisely the same fashion by Safavid philosophers, antiquarianist-perennialists to a man; his synthesis of metaphysical speculation and mystical-magical practice was highly salient to those thinkers who sought to do the same.¹² This boom in explicitly Neopythagorean and occult-scientific forms of Neoplatonism is epitomized by the resurgence in popularity of the *Epistles (Rasā'il)* of the Brethren of Purity (Ikhwān al-Ṣafā') in Safavid scholarly circles, especially by way of their abridged Persian translation, *Epitome of Philosophy (Mujmal al-ḥikma)*.¹³ Given its Neopythagorean

phenomenological and religionist approach to the subject committed him to these categories, which continue to structure much of modern scholarship on Islam.

10 On Islamic Neopythagoreanism see e.g. Izdebska, "Pythagorean Philosophy"; Melvin-Koushki, "The New Brethren"; Terrier, "La figure de Pythagore." On this philosophical current in the Greek and Latin contexts see e.g. Huffmann, "Pythagoreanism."

11 See e.g. Joost-Gaugier, *Pythagoras and Renaissance Europe*.

12 See e.g. the long entry on Pythagoras in Quṭb al-Dīn Ishkawārī Lāhijī, *Maḥbūb al-qulūb*, 1121, 208-36; and Terrier, "La représentation de la sagesse grecque," 306-11; idem, *Histoire de la sagesse*, 373-420; idem, "La figure de Pythagore."

13 Melvin-Koushki, "Powers of One," 165. Abū l-Qāsim Anṣārī Kāzīrūnī (fl. 1605), for instance, a prominent Shirazi scholar in the service, like Mīr Dāmād, of Shah 'Abbās – and a student, not incidentally, of Ibn Turka's great-great-great grandson Afḍal al-Dīn b. Ḥabīb Allāh Turka (d. 991/1583) –, gushes of them in his *Ladder to the Heavens (Sullam al-samāwāt)*, an eclectic, genre-bending and heavily pro-occultist work equal parts theological tract, history of philosophy, literary history and encyclopedia of the sciences (205):

There is not a single word in the *Epistles* that this wretch has not read repeatedly with the eye of desire and longing ... In some of these epistles it is stated that on most topics their discussion accords with the doctrine of Pythagoras.

bent, therefore, we should expect Safavid philosophy to be characterized by a certain mathematizing tendency – as indeed was the case, and from the very beginning of the Safavid period.

The Aqquyunlu-cum-Safavid philosopher-astronomer Shams al-Dīn Khafri (d. 942/1535) is here a case in point.¹⁴ This Shirazi thinker, who adjusted smoothly to the Safavid takeover and enjoyed excellent relations with Shah Ismāʿil (r. 907-30/1501-24), has been identified by George Saliba as the most important planetary theorist of the 10th/16th century, and the first in any tradition to redefine mathematics “as a descriptive language of scientific processes”; he takes this pioneering contribution as foreshadowing “the modern conception of the role of mathematics in science in general.”¹⁵ The problematically teleological nature of this argument aside, Khafri was indeed in the vanguard of those Neopythagoreanizing philosophers who effectively freed astronomy from Aristotelian physics; more specifically, he was responsible for continuing the revolutionary project of the Timurid mathematical astronomers of the Samarkand Observatory of Ulugh Beg (r. 810-53/1409-49) – who, recent research suggests, were the immediate intellectual forebears of Copernicus (d. 1543), Khafri’s contemporary.¹⁶

In short, the quest to mathematize the cosmos was first launched in Iran and Transoxania, not in Europe; communicated westward by Byzantine Jewish scholars and perhaps Venetian envoys;¹⁷ then pursued concurrently but separately in both regions during the 16th and 17th centuries.¹⁸ That this quest did not result in “scientific modernity” in the Persianate world but did in the Latinate is simply evidence of different metaphysical and cultural priorities as pursued within different sociopolitical structures, and must not distract us from the remarkable degree of early modern Islamo-Christianate intellectual continuity – a continuity driven in no small part by a common identification

14 On Khafri’s thought in general see Saatchian, *Gottes Wesen – Gottes Wirken*; Terrier, “Khafri, Shams al-Dīn.”

15 Saliba, “Khafri, Šams-al-Din,” *EIr*.

16 On the mathematical turn see e.g. Saliba, “A Sixteenth-Century Arabic Critique”; Ragep, “Copernicus and His Islamic Predecessors”; Fazlhoğlu, “Between Reality and Mentality”; Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One”; idem, “The New Brethren.”

17 Morrison, “A Scholarly Intermediary.”

18 Ottoman astronomy represents an exception to this mathematizing trend; while the science (together with its astrological applications) continued to be vigorously pursued and patronized, Ottoman astronomers were more conservative and remained wedded to Avicennan physics (Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One,” 172-79). On occultism both within and against the Avicennan tradition in the early modern era, and as a major but as yet almost entirely unexplored front in “post-classical” Islamicate intellectual history, see Gutas, “Avicenna and After.”

with Pythagoras, practically expressed through the pursuit of occult-scientific divinization of the self and theurgic control of the world through number.

Some Safavid philosophers, then, were just as thoroughgoing in their Neopythagoreanism as their European counterparts, and performed theosis through practices both mystical and occultist.¹⁹ But what links Neopythagorean theory with occult-scientific practice? In the case of Renaissance Europe, the emergence of *Christian kabbalah* served this purpose: born in late 15th-century Italy, it became a popular intellectual pursuit in Latinate scholarship by the 17th. (Its humanist father, Giovanni Pico della Mirandola (d. 1494), famously posited the science as the most effective means of harmonizing Plato and Aristotle and achieving the divinization of man.²⁰) I therefore posit kabbalah's coeval Arabic cognate, the occult science of letters (*'ilm al-ḥurūf*), or *lettrism*, as that missing link in the contemporary Persianate context.²¹ A primary expression of Islamicate Neopythagoreanism from at least the 3rd/9th century onward, by the early 9th/15th century lettrism was widely considered to be not only the most Islamic of all the occult sciences, but the most Islamic, and the most universal, of *all* sciences in its status as both the chiefest branch of the

19 To be clear, I do not mean to argue that a commitment to Neoplatonism entailed a commitment to either Neopythagoreanism or occult science, only that such commitments seem to have been closely correlated, as with Mīr Dāmād in particular.

20 See e.g. Wirszubski, *Pico della Mirandola's Encounter*.

21 Lettrism, as an umbrella science, encompasses the two modes of applied occultism as a whole in its basic division into letter magic (*sīmīyā'*) on the one hand and letter divination (*jafr*) on the other. Letter-magical techniques include most prominently the construction of talismans (sg. *ṭilasm*), usually defined as devices that conjunct celestial influences with terrestrial objects in order to produce a strange (*gharīb*) effect according with the will (*nīyya*, *himma*) of the practitioner. The engine of a talisman is typically a magic square (*wafiq al-a'dād*), which may be populated with letters or numbers relevant to the operation at hand; these are designed to harness the specific letter-numerical virtues of personal names, whether of humans, jinn or angels, phrases or quranic passages, or one or more of the names of God. The latter operation, it should be noted, is a typical example of the Sufi-occultist practice of *theomimesis* – hence the divine names as a major focus of lettrism, often termed for that reason *'ilm al-ḥurūf wa-l-asmā'*, or even simply *'ilm al-asmā'*, 'the science of names.' Letter divination, for its part, includes most prominently the construction of a comprehensive prognosticon (*jafr jāmi'*), a 784-page text containing every possible permutation of the letters of the Arabic alphabet; this device is associated in the first place with 'Alī b. Abī Ṭālib, its inventor. From such a prognosticon may be derived the name of every thing or being that has ever existed or will ever exist, every name of God in every language, and the knowledge of past, present and future events – especially political events – to the end of time. The divinatory aspect of lettrism is further pegged to the mysterious separated sura-initial letters in the Quran (*muqatta'āt*), similarly held to contain comprehensive predictive power, and to have inspired the basic lettrist technique of *taksīr*, separating the letters of words or names for the purposes of permutation.

‘science of divine unity’ (*‘ilm al-tawhīd*) and the ‘science of the saints’ (*‘ilm al-awliyā*) *par excellence*. So argued Ibn ‘Arabī (d. 638/1240), foremost theoretician of *walāya*, and his argument was comprehensively systematized by Timurid and Ottoman occult philosophers like Ṣā’in al-Dīn Turka Iṣfahānī (d. 835/1432) and ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Biṣṭāmī (d. 858/1454) respectively, leading members of the New Brethren of Purity scholarly network radiating from Mamluk Cairo to the east and north.²²

Most importantly for the purposes of his Safavid heirs, Ibn Turka in particular, a Sunni, was responsible for recasting lettrism in both ‘Alid and perennialist terms: simultaneously a patrimony of Pythagoras, chief disciple of the prophet-king Solomon, and ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib, sole vector of sacral power (*walāya*) during the Islamic dispensation, for Shi‘i and Sunni alike.²³ I have shown elsewhere that the need to harness and routinize Shah Ismā‘īl’s unstable messianic charisma as avatar of God and reincarnation of ‘Alī resulted in a distinctive ‘Alidism-Sufism-occultism complex as the engine of Safavid imperial ideology until at least the mid-11th/17th century; this complex, featuring *walāya* as its common term, was in turn synergetic with the antiquarianist Neoplatonic-Neopythagorean proclivities of Safavid philosophy.²⁴ Its great project: to subsume, transform and transcend mainstream Sunni Avicennism, to marry Plato and Aristotle, through a dual focus on the Imams and the ancients. That Ibn Turka’s imamophilic-perennialist brand of lettrism – *the science of ‘Alid-Pythagorean walāya* – comprised the same components and pursued an identical project made it perfectly fitted to Safavid intellectual and religio-political needs.²⁵

For Safavid philosophers to single out such a germane and mainstream Timurid intellectual current for exclusion from their ambitious, universalist project of synthesis, incorporating every other school of thought mainstream by the end of the 9th/15th century, thus seems unlikely and uncharacteristic in the extreme. Yet this is precisely the impression that current scholarship

22 The first monograph-length study of the New Brethren as an informal network is Binbaş, *Intellectual Networks*; see also Melvin-Koushki, “The New Brethren”; Fleischer, “Ancient Wisdom”; Fazlhoğlu, “İhvanu’s-Safâ ve Abdurrahman Bistâmî”; Gardiner, “Occultist Encyclopedism.” Significantly, they adopted this appellation to broadcast their intention to revive and expand the occult-philosophical and Neopythagorean project of the original *Ikhwān al-Ṣafā*’ of Abbasid Iraq.

23 Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest,” 315–20. It is here significant that Ibn Turka breaks with Ibn ‘Arabī, otherwise his exemplar, to reassociate the Seal of Sainthood (*khātam al-walāya*) solely with ‘Alī; see n. 92 below. Likewise, Ibn Turka appears to be the first Muslim thinker to so explicitly associate Pythagoras with both Solomon and ‘Alī.

24 Melvin-Koushki, “Empire.”

25 On these needs see e.g. Babayan, *Mystics, Monarchs, and Messiahs*.

gives. The overwhelming majority of studies on the period mention occult sciences not at all or in merest passing, while those intellectual histories of Safavid philosophy-science that do acknowledge their popularity often banish them, as an undifferentiated mass, to the dumping ground that is “mysticism,” or worse, “popular religion,” even “superstition.”²⁶ Lettrism itself becomes, at best, “numerology”; *jafr* is occasionally cited – as a popular Shi‘i religious practice of no particular scientific or political value.²⁷ Of high Ibn ‘Arabian-Ibn Turkian philosophical lettrism – tantamount, from the 9th/15th century onward, to Islamic Neopythagorean philosophy as such – there is not a trace.²⁸

This dismissive historiographical attitude toward the occult sciences, despite their patent ubiquity in Safavid (and Mughal and Ottoman) elite and popular culture alike, is a product of modern *scientistic* and *religionist* approaches to early modern Islamicate intellectual and cultural history more generally. Effectively, these approaches, though violently opposed, have nevertheless conspired to historiographically accomplish what premodern Muslim and Christian anti-occultist puritans never could: the erasure of Magic as the middle term between Science and Religion, and hence from society as a whole. Needless to say, such partisan championing of outsider, polemical discourses, static as a rule, to the exclusion of insider, practitioner discourses, constantly evolving, is not considered legitimate in any other field of historical inquiry; but otherwise excellent positivist and religionist historians continue to make an exception for Islamic Magic.²⁹

This *occult exception* has had an especially deleterious effect on Safavid intellectual historiography: it is permitted to the Enlightened modern historian to simply reprise the hostile arguments of a minority of contemporary Muslim jurists and theologians, on the one hand, and the equally hostile but far less informed opinions of European Christian visitors to the Safavid realm, on the

26 An exception is Babayan, “Cosmological Order.”

27 By contrast, the popular and related occult art of bibliomancy has received some attention; see e.g. Gruber, “The ‘Restored’ Shi‘i *muṣḥaf* as Divine Guide?”

28 The field of (Neo)pythagorean studies remains overwhelmingly eurocentric and classicocentric as a rule. Thus we are permitted to speak, for example, of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’ of 4th/10th-century Iraq as culmination of late-antique occult-scientific Neopythagoreanism (Fowden, *Before and after Muḥammad*, 204-7); but there is no hint in the literature as to an ever greater boom in Islamicate Neopythagoreanism thereafter, this through its fusion with lettrism. The sole exception is the forthcoming Brill two-volume *Companion to the Reception of Pythagoras and Pythagoreanism*, edited by Aurélien Robert, Irene Caiazzo and Constantin Macris, which does give some attention to this boom, including the present author’s study “The New Brethren.”

29 For this diagnosis, with examples and references, see Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One”; idem, “Is (Islamic) Occult Science Science?”; Otto, “Magie im Islam.”

other, both of which decry the pervasive “superstitiousness” of Safavid elite and popular society.³⁰ And even strictly empirical historians of early modern Iran (the overwhelming majority) have often inadvertently contributed to the disenchantment of Safavid society by passing over this awkward occult controversy in tactful silence. Hence the irresistible appeal of Mullā Ṣadrā in modern historiography, his magnetic brilliance aside: this thinker’s apparent disregard, at least in writing, for the occult-scientific, theurgical and indeed imperial applications of his thoroughgoingly Neoplatonic philosophy – in sharp contrast to many of his scholarly contemporaries and teachers – sets us post-Enlightenment moderns at ease. We may slot him neatly into Religion, not Science, and certainly not Empire.

Perhaps most emblematic of the violence scientistic-religionist occultophobia has done to the sources is the transformation in the literature, from Corbin onward, of a major Sunni imperial occult philosopher like Ibn Turka into a *Shiʿi-Sufi* – which is to say, a purely *religious* – thinker, the better to serve as apolitical link in the specifically Shiʿi chain of intellectual ascent from Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī to Mullā Ṣadrā. That the central focus of his project is *lettrist* and its tenor vociferously *imperialist* is simply ignored as incompatible with this teleology.³¹

Their violence to the sources aside, such acts of elision reinforce the image of Safavid philosophy as a *sui generis* phenomenon by further attenuating

30 A *locus classicus* of the latter is the patronizing observation by the Huguenot sojourner Jean Chardin (d. 1713) of Iranian society in the 11th/17th century (quoted in Massé, *Persian Beliefs and Customs*, 240): “[M]ost [Persians] are dependent on astrologers and other diviners as a child is dependent on its nurse.”

31 Corbin, “Typologie des spirituels selon Sâ’inoddīn ‘Alī Ispahānī (ob. 830/1427) [sic],” in idem, *En islam iranien*, 3:233–74. On other such tendentious misrepresentations of Ibn Turka in modern scholarship see Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest,” 6–8. In Iran his modern reputation rests almost exclusively on his *Tamhīd al-Qawāʿid*, an elegant, synthetic Avicennan-Illuminationist-Ibn ‘Arabian treatment of the concept of absolute being (*al-wujūd al-muṭlaq*), which has long featured as a staple teaching text in Twelver seminary curricula; yet its author was quite insistent as to the inadequacy of such a concept as a basis for metaphysics, meaning that a work like the *Tamhīd* must be considered to be of strictly secondary importance when judging Ibn Turka’s project as a whole. In his most recent summa of Islamicate philosophy, Seyyed Hossein Nasr does go so far as to acknowledge Ibn Turka’s status as “a member of the Ḥurūfī school” (an extremely problematic designation, as I have shown (ibid., 417–33)), and even distinguishes between “Ḥurūfīs” and “Shiʿite esotericists”; but he celebrates him solely as a synthesizing Shiʿi thinker, “at once an *ishrāqī*, a *mashshāʿī*, and an *ʿarif* of the school of Ibn ‘Arabī,” and singles out the *Tamhīd al-Qawāʿid* as epitomizing Ibn Turka’s project (*Islamic Philosophy*, 116, 209–10). Nasr further, and rightly, associates Neopythagoreanism with both Ibn ‘Arabī and Ismaʿilism, and particularly the Ikhwān al-Ṣafāʾ, yet gives no indication as to its renaissance as a mainstream intellectual current in the Safavid period (ibid., 39–40, 111–12).

its connection with immediate Mamluk-Timurid-Aqquyunlu precedent specifically, and contemporary Persianate and Latinate parallels generally. More perniciously, they make impossible a history of the practice of Safavid philosophy, which, again, was often overtly occultist and imperialist: a number of leading Safavid philosophers of the 10th/16th and 11th/17th centuries feature in some contemporary and traditional sources as professional lettrists in service to the Safavid ruling elite, master talismanists responsible for protecting the realm from plague and invasion and letter-magically directing its political course. This includes in the first place such luminaries as Ghiyāth al-Dīn Manṣūr Dashtakī (d. 949/1542), personal letter mage to Shah Ṭahmāsb (r. 930-84/1524-76), as well as the three founding members of the so-called school of Isfahan under Shah ‘Abbās (r. 995-1038/1587-1629): Mīr Dāmād (d. 1041/1631), Shaykh Bahā’ī (d. 1030/1621) and Mīr Findiriskī (d. 1050/1640).³² Khafrī himself authored treatises on *jafr* and geomancy (*‘ilm al-raml*) both;³³ more tellingly, he was also father of the most prolific and influential Persian writer on operative lettrism of the 10th/16th century, Maḥmūd Dihdār Shīrāzī (fl. 1576), aspiring courtier to Shah Ismā‘īl II (r. 984-85/1576-77) and Shaykh Bahā’ī’s teacher in the occult sciences, who was responsible for Twelverizing Timurid lettrism for Safavid purposes.³⁴ As for Mīr Dāmād: he famously repelled the Ottoman attack on Hamadan in 1630, after the Qizilbash defense had collapsed – solely by means of theurgic-talismanic prayer.³⁵

32 On these sources – wherein even Ibn Sīnā himself is cited as a lettrist to be feared – see Subtelný, “Kāshifī’s *Asrār-i qāsimī*”; Melvin-Koushki, *The Occult Science of Empire*. Ghiyāth al-Dīn, for instance, famously assassinated Amir Dhū l-Fiqr, the unsubmissive governor of Baghdad, by means of talismanic magic, thereby facilitating the Safavid takeover of the city in 1508 (Shūstari, *Majālis al-mu‘minīn*, 2:232; Bdaiwī, “Shi‘ī Defenders of Avicenna,” 249). While Mīr Dāmād and Shaykh Bahā’ī focused their energies on theoretical and applied lettrism, however, Mīr Findiriskī’s interests tended more toward alchemy, and he famously spent many years in India pursuing mastery of this science (together with yoga) (Rizvi, “Mir Fendereski,” *Elr*). Intriguingly, the distinctive Safavid dual alchemy-lettrism platform that was developed during the 10th/16th and 11th/17th centuries, particularly on display in the many philosophical anthologies produced then, parallels a tendency among contemporary European thinkers to combine alchemy and kabbalah (see Forshaw, “*Cabala Chymica* or *Chemia Cabalistica*”). That said, much further research will need to be done to substantiate these thinkers’ purported occult-scientific service to empire.

33 Saatchian, *Gottes Wesen – Gottes Wirken*, 51-54. It is significant in this connection that geomancy, Arabic answer to the *I Ching*, was reclassified as a mathematical – which is to say Neopythagorean – science from the late 6th/12th century onward; even alchemy was included in the mathematizing trend that swept the post-Mongol Islamicate world (Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One”).

34 Melvin-Koushki, “Maḥmūd Dehdār Shīrāzi,” *Elr*; idem, *The Occult Science of Empire*.

35 This feat is reported by his great-grandson Mīr Muḥammad Ashraf ‘Alawī (d. 1130/1718); see Ja’fariyān, *Maqālāt-i tārikhiyya*, 12:242; idem, *Naqsh-i khāndān-i Karakī*, 409-10.

But what bearing do such lettrist linkages have on the status of Khafī and Shaykh Bahā'ī as leading astronomers and mathematicians of their day? Did Shaykh Bahā'ī and Mīr Dāmād consider their letter magicking a simple hobby?

Hardly: it is my contention that the dramatic Neopythagorean-perennialist turn that defines Safavid philosophy cannot be adequately explained without reference to lettrism, and specifically its Ibn Turkian formulation – a distinctively Sunni intellectual current utilized by certain leading Twelver Shi'i scholars to help construct a new Safavid imperial culture.³⁶ Lettrism is also an ideal entrée into the study of Safavid philosophical practice, since it, like its sister occult sciences, was a discrete discipline regulated by teaching texts considered canonical by the 10th/16th century, and constellated a metaphysics-mathematics-magic continuum whose applications were explicitly experientialist (*tajribī*).³⁷ For letter-number is the *coincidentia oppositorum*: it renders the immaterial material; unites Occult (*bāṭin*) with Manifest (*ẓāhir*), First (*awwal*) with Last (*ākhir*); makes the One many and the many One; marries heaven and earth.³⁸ Lettrism represents, in other words, the nexus of philosophy and politics, of science and empire; its greatest exponents

However, while Mīr Dāmād was certainly known to practice letter magic, his colleague Shaykh Bahā'ī achieved far more renown in the field of applied lettrism; for examples see Melvin-Koushki, *The Occult Science of Empire*.

36 This is not to suggest that Safavid scholars did not draw on the specifically Twelver Shi'i lettrist tradition in equal measure, particularly as represented by the Iraqi scholar al-Ḥāfiẓ Rajab al-Bursī, Ibn Turka's contemporary – and, significantly, fellow Ibn 'Arabian-Būnian lettrist; see below.

37 As 'Alī Ṣafī Kāshifī (d. 939/1533), son of Ḥusayn Wā'iz Kāshifī (d. 910/1505) and a lettrist like his more famous father, puts it in his instructive manual on the subject, *Amulet of Protection from the Trials of Time* (*Ḥirz al-amān min fitan al-zamān*), written soon after the Safavid conquest for the benefit of a courtly audience (trans. in Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 280):

The experiential findings (*tajriba*) of lettermasters (*arbāb-i ḥurūf*) stand irrefutable testimony to [the fact that the imaginal forms of the letters can be harnessed to produce effects in the physical world] ... Experimentation aimed at manifesting the effects and properties of the letters has often been successfully repeated; and experiment is among the forms of proof that produce certainty (*tajriba yakī az isbāt-i yaqīn ast*).

38 The verse *He is the First and the Last, the Manifest and the Occult* (Q 57:3) is the central motto of Ibn Turka and his lettrist colleagues. On the doctrine of *coincidentia oppositorum* as the basis of lettrist theory see below. It should be noted in this connection that in the Arabo-Persian encyclopedic tradition talismans are typically defined as letter-magical devices conjuncting celestial virtues with terrestrial objects (see e.g. Quṭb al-Dīn Shīrāzī, *Durrat al-tāj*, 155-56).

were influential in terms both metaphysical and physical.³⁹ As such, the science must be considered indispensable to any intellectual or social history of the early modern Persianate world generally and Safavid Iran specifically, for all that it has been dispensed with in the literature to date. More broadly, its rehabilitation among Safavidists will also serve to facilitate comparative early modern Islamo-Judeo-Christianate intellectual history; the Neopythagorean quest to decode the Two Books, scripture and nature, was in no way exclusive to western Europe, but pursued with equal intensity in the Persianate east: world as (Arabic) text.⁴⁰

As a first step toward repairing this major lacuna, then, this article surveys the lettrist writings of Mīr Dāmād, here taken as an outstanding but representative example. Significantly, even the most cursory examination of these texts shows Mīr Dāmād to be a conscious heir of Ibn Turka in particular: not only does the Safavid thinker quote his Timurid predecessor directly, but he too declares lettrist Neopythagoreanism to be the basis of his entire philosophical system. An equally important source for Mīr Dāmād in this connection is the Aqqyunlu philosopher Jalāl al-Dīn Dawānī (d. 908/1502), author of two lettrist treatises and prominent exponent of Ibn Turkian lettrism. That Safavid philosophy was largely an outgrowth of the infamous, often vitriolic Dawānī-Dashtakī rivalry of the late 9th/15th and early 10th/16th centuries, with Dawānī representing a synthesizing if eclectic Illuminationist-Ibn ‘Arabian-Ash‘ari trend and the Dashtakī (Mīr Šadr al-Dīn (d. 903/1498) and his son Ghiyāth al-Dīn Maṣṣūr) representing a purist Avicennan reaction thereto,⁴¹ is widely recognized among specialists; Mīr Dāmād’s reception of Dawānī as a leading *lettrist* authority thus further clarifies the nature of the latter’s influence in the Safavid period, suggesting that he played a more pivotal role in the Safavid turn away from Aristotelianism and toward Neoplatonism and Neopythagoreanism than has heretofore been recognized.⁴² (Indeed, in his magnum opus and final work, *Revealing the Muḥammadan Realities* (*Kashf al-ḥaqā’iq al-muḥammadiyya*), Ghiyāth al-Dīn Dashtakī himself identifies lettrism as an important front on

39 This is not to suggest that lettrism always entailed imperialism, to the contrary; but it appears to have often done so in the early modern Persianate courtly context.

40 For references see Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One.” Cf. Sayyid Ḥaydar Āmulī’s (d. after 787/1385) theory of the Three Books: the Book of God, the Book of Souls and the Book of Horizons (see Terrier, “Sayyid Ḥaydar Āmulī”); and Ibn Barrajān’s (d. 536/1141) insistence on “the principle of correspondence between man, creation, and revelation” (Casewit, *The Mystics*, 71).

41 Bdaiwi, “Shi‘i Defenders of Avicenna.”

42 More generally, as Rizvi notes (“*al-Qabasāt*,” 460), “we need to carefully reconsider the influence of Dawānī’s philosophical positions in the Safavid period.”

which Dawānī sought to compete with his father; in retaliation, he advances astrological, physiognomical and lettrist proofs for the latter's philosophical and moral superiority to the former.⁴³) Finally, a comparison of Mīr Dāmād's lettrist works with their sources shows him to be singlehandedly responsible for the Neopythagoreanization of Ibn Sīnā himself, the second Aristotle – an unprecedented transmogrification that epitomizes the project of much of Safavid philosophy as a distinctive unit.

Mīr Dāmād as Neopythagorean-Lettrist: Safavidizing Ibn Sīnā, Ibn Turka and Dawānī

Famously hailed the Third Teacher (*al-mu'allim al-thālith*),⁴⁴ Sayyid Muḥammad Bāqir Ḥusaynī Astarābādī, aka Mīr Dāmād, was among the most intellectually and politically influential men of the Safavid realm: intimate of Shah 'Abbās; sometime *shaykh al-islām* of Isfāhan; and teacher to Mullā Ṣadrā and other leading Safavid philosophers, including Sayyid Aḥmad al-'Alawī al-Āmilī (d. btw. 1054-60/1644-50), Quṭb al-Dīn Ishkawārī Lāhījī (d. btw. 1088-95/1677-84) and Mullā Shamsā Gilānī (d. 1098/1687).⁴⁵ In the latter role, of course, he is often styled chief founder of the so-called school of Isfāhan, which furthered his synthesis of Avicennan and Illuminationist philosophy with Ibn 'Arabian theory and Twelver theology.⁴⁶ The longstanding debate over the ontological primacy of existence (*wujūd*) versus that of essence or quiddity (*māhiyya*) was reinvigorated under his aegis; unlike his greatest student, Mullā Ṣadrā, who powerfully reasserted and refined the Avicennan existentialist position, Mīr Dāmād defended Illuminationist essentialism. His most celebrated contribution to Islamicate philosophy is the concept of perpetual creation (*ḥudūth dahrī*), whereby divine creative agency is operative on an intermediate plane of time and existence he terms perpetuity (*dahr*), that is,

43 *Kashf al-ḥaqā'iq al-muḥammadiyya*, 2:980-87; my thanks to Ahab Bdaiwi for this reference. Ghiyāth al-Dīn's occultist throwdown is translated and analyzed in Melvin-Koushki, *The Occult Science of Empire*, ch. 4. It should be noted in this connection that Mīr Ṣadr al-Dīn himself penned no less than three lettrist works: *R. fī Taḥqīq al-ḥurūf* and *R. al-Zubur wa-l-bayyināt*, both lost; and *R. Istikhrāj asāmi l-a'imma bi-ḥisāb al-abjad*, of which a unicam copy is preserved in the Mashhad University Faculty of Theology collection, MS 976/8 (copied 1180/1767) (Bdaiwi, "Shi'i Defenders," 373-74).

44 I.e., after Aristotle and Fārābī.

45 Newman, "Dāmād, Mīr," *Elr*.

46 See e.g. Nasr, *Islamic Philosophy*, 212-16.

relative eternity or meta-time, thereby reconciling the otherwise irreconcilable Neoplatonic-Aristotelian emanationist and quranic accounts of creation.⁴⁷

In his own day and after, if not in modern scholarship, Mīr Dāmād was also cast in specifically occult terms. He thus figures in contemporary sources as a master talismanist in service of the Safavid state, and in Iran even today as an author on the occult sciences.⁴⁸ As his Medinan-Shirazi biographer Sayyid ‘Alī-Khān Ibn Ma’sūm (d. 1120/1709) emphasizes, moreover, it was our philosopher’s penchant for the ritual recitation of divine names – the central focus of the letter magic of the post-Mongol era – as his primary form of spiritual practice that best proves his attainment of theosis. As a case in point, Ibn Ma’sūm copies in full Mīr Dāmād’s brief, ornate Arabic treatise *On Doffing* (*R. al-Khal‘iyya*), written in 1614, wherein the latter details a remarkable out-of-body experience in which he explored every level of physical and metaphysical being, and perceived directly the realm of perpetuity subsuming time (*ṭawaytu iqlīm al-zamān wa-ṣirtu ilā ‘ālam al-dahr*) – solely by means of the divine names All-sufficient (*al-ghani*) and Enricher (*al-mughni*).⁴⁹ (The ‘science of divestment’ (*‘ilm al-tajrīd*) – i.e., what is now termed OBE by parapsychologists and astral projection by New Agers – was likewise ranked as the chiefest of all (occult) sciences by the Brethren of Purity, those exemplary Neopythagoreans, together with alchemy, astrology, magic and medicine, the mastery of which is prerequisite for human perfection.⁵⁰) That the infamously strict traditionist Muḥammad Bāqir Majlisī (d. 1111/1699) saw fit to copy Ibn Ma’sūm’s account verbatim is here highly significant;⁵¹ in sharp contrast to earlier doctrinaire scholars, indeed, this leading architect of Safavid Twelver orthodoxy is elsewhere constrained to argue for the validity of lettrism by positing *Islam as magic*.⁵²

47 Rizvi, “Mīr Dāmād in India,” 11; idem, “*al-Qabasāt*”; Terrier, “De l’éternité.”

48 See nn. 32 above and 155 below. This aspect of his sociopolitical persona and legacy is noted by both Rizvi (“*al-Qabasāt*,” 440) and Terrier (“Mīr Dāmād,” 126).

49 *Sulāfat al-‘aṣr*, 2:777–78. This treatise is studied and translated in Corbin, “Confessions extatiques de Mīr Dāmād (1041/1631),” in idem, *En islam iranien*, 4:9–53; and see now Terrier, “Mīr Dāmād,” 152–56.

50 *Rasā’il*, 4:286–87. For a recent summary of the state of the field of parapsychology, including research on out-of-body and near-death experiences, see Kelly, Crabtree and Marshall, eds., *Beyond Physicalism*.

51 *Biḥār al-anwār*, 106:123–26.

52 Specifically, in a remarkably contradictory section of his summary Persian legal work on *ḥudūd* punishments and murder law, *R. Ḥudūd u qisās u diyāt*, Muḥammad Bāqir Majlisī treats of magic or sorcery (Ar. *siḥr*, Pers. *jādū*) as being among those serious crimes meriting severe punishment, in this case the death penalty (§1.7.1, 53–57). He here proposes a maximalist definition of sorcery as including everything from planetary invocation and jinn subjugation to soothsaying and amuletry: any technique that attempts to influence others’ bodies, hearts or minds falls under this rubric, even harmless illusionism and

More recently, ‘Allāma Ḥasan Ḥasanzāda Āmulī (b. 1347/1929) – likewise an author on lettrism – compared one of his visionary experiences, the product his recitation of the *tahlīl*, to that of Mīr Dāmād as recorded in this treatise.⁵³ To explain our philosopher’s early modern status, finally, at least one modern hagiography therefore goes so far as to present his birth as being itself occult-scientifically determined: Muḥammad ‘Alī Mudarris Tabrīzī’s (d. 1373/1953) *Rayḥānat al-adab* states that it was arranged by means of oneiromancy (*ta’bīr al-ru’yā*) at the instance of ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib – this in order to produce a child who would be ‘heir to the sciences of the prophets and Imams.’⁵⁴

It is therefore hardly surprising – lettrism being the science of the Imams *par excellence* – that Mīr Dāmād wrote three works wholly or substantially lettrist in orientation. The first and most important of these is *Firebrands and Epiphanies* (*Jadhawāt u mawāqīt*), his only major work in Persian; it offers a full, and characteristically ornate, treatment of his philosophical system within an explicitly Neopythagorean-lettrist framework.⁵⁵ It was written sometime between 1614-26 at the request of Shah ‘Abbās that he answer the problem, then exercising several scholars in India, of Moses’s encounter with God as related in Q 7:143: why was the mountain destroyed by the divine self-manifestation but Moses left unscathed? The second is *The Lamp of Illumination and Keeping the Balance: An Exposition of the Concept of Appearance, Furnishing Proof for the Efficacy of Prayer* (*Nibrās al-dīyā’ wa-taswā’ al-sawā’ fī sharḥ bāb al-badā’ wa-ithbāt jadhā l-du’ā*).⁵⁶ This curiously composite Arabic work formally treats of the topic of *badā’* (lit. ‘appearance’), or apparent change in the divine will, a central focus of Twelver theology-cum-historiography; at the same

prestidigitation, as well as all types of talismans, magic-square-based or otherwise – even those harnessing divine names or quranic verses are suspect. Yet he immediately proceeds to claim, wildly counterfactually, that all such forms of sorcery simply went largely extinct with the coming of Islam, and cannot work in properly pious environments like Iran – where every arm, he approvingly reports, is fitted with a quranic or divine-names talisman! For a fuller discussion of this and other cases touched on in this article, see Melvin-Koushki, *The Occult Science of Empire*.

53 *Hizār u yak kalima*, 5:254-56.

54 *Rayḥānat al-adab*, 6:56-58; see Terrier, “Mīr Dāmād,” 128-29.

55 Ed. ‘Alī Awjābī, with glosses by Mullā ‘Alī Nūrī, Tehran: Mīrāth-i Maktūb, 1380 Sh./2001. See Biḥbahānī, *Ḥakīm-i Astarābād*, 128-29.

56 Ed. Ḥamid Nājī Iṣfahānī, with glosses by Mullā ‘Alī Nūrī, Tehran: Hijrat, 1374 Sh./1995. See Biḥbahānī, *Ḥakīm-i Astarābād*, 171-72. It must here be emphasized that Mīr Dāmād’s theory of prayer and the means of ensuring its efficacy are thoroughly letter-magical in tenor: *prayer as mathematical science*. Similarly, his earlier contemporary Taṣköprüzāde Aḥmed (d. 968/1561), the great Ottoman polymath and encyclopedist, reclassified the various branches of lettrism from the natural and mathematical sciences to the *quranic* (Melvin-Koushki, “Powers of One,” 173-76).

time, it contains occasional discussions of lettrist theory, and features an appendix cataloguing the occult properties of each letter of the Arabic alphabet. (This appendix also circulated independently under the title *Letters and Numbers* (*al-Ḥurūf wa-l-a'dād*).⁵⁷) Mīr Dāmād refers in both this work and the later *Firebrands* to his authorship of another treatise in this vein: *Ta'wīl al-muqaṭṭa'āt* (aka *R. dar Asrār-i muqaṭṭa'āt*), on the mysterious separated sura-initial letters in the Quran, though the treatise appears to have been lost.⁵⁸

The *Nibrās* has most recently been studied by Mathieu Terrier, who notes that despite its status as a minor work, it has the great virtue of bringing together three major strands of Mīr Dāmād's scholarly project in a way that his major works generally do not: "pure" philosophy, exemplified by his *Qabasāt* and *Taqwīm al-īmān*; Shi'i tradition, as in *al-Rawāshiḥ al-samāwiyya*, an introduction-commentary to al-Kulaynī's *Uṣūl al-kāfi*; and the occult sciences, particularly lettrism. Most crucially for our purposes here, the Astarabadi sage transforms *badā'* into a robust philosophical category, for the first time in the Twelver Shi'i tradition, precisely by inserting it into a Neopythagorean-emanationist Two Books (Quran and cosmos) framework: the mutability of appearance is to the text that is historical time as abrogation (*naskh*) is to the text of previous scriptural revelation.⁵⁹ He concludes the treatise with a lettrist analysis of the term *badā'* itself, which serves to ontologically guarantee the validity of the preceding metaphysical and traditionist analysis. "[W]ith this concept," in sum, "Mīr Dāmād opened the way to a Shi'i philosophy of history, something without precedent in the history of Islamic philosophy, and which remained unexplored after him."⁶⁰ It also opened the way to a Shi'i *science* of history, whereby the adept may anticipate – and therefore change – historical "appearances" by means of lettrist operations, often tantamount to both miracles and "answered prayer," which is to say, *theurgy*.

But Mīr Dāmād does not here expand on this latter point; the *Nibrās* rather refers the reader to his much fuller and more definitive discussions

57 Bihbahānī, *Ḥakīm-i Astarābād*, 138.

58 The *Ta'wīl al-muqaṭṭa'āt* would seem to have been written as a separate work sometime before the completion of the *Nibrās* and the commencement of the *Jadhawāt*; Mīr Dāmād also refers the reader thereto at the end of the *Qabasāt* (ibid., 123). No copies are known to survive, although the bias against matters lettrist in modern scholarship suggests the possibility that at least one does but has yet to be properly identified.

59 Terrier, "The Wisdom of God," 104-5, 116-17; and see below.

60 Ibid., 128-29, 132. But cf. the similarly Neopythagorean-occultist theory of history propounded by the New Brother Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī, on which see Melvin-Koushki, "In Defense of Geomancy"; idem, "The New Brethren"; and below.

thereof in the *Jadhawāt* and the *Ta'wīl al-muqāṭṭa'āt*.⁶¹ For reasons of space, I will therefore focus in what follows on the *Jadhawāt*, given that it offers the most explicit answer to the question posed in this study: To what extent did philosophical lettrism survive as a mainstream scientific-and-religious current in the high Safavid period, and what were its sources?

In *Firebrands and Epiphanies*, as elsewhere, Mīr Dāmād compares and contrasts what he calls his Yemeni or oriental philosophy (*al-ḥikma al-yamāniyya*) with Greek precedent (*al-ḥikma al-yūnāniyya*).⁶² The former is his trademark Avicennan-Illuminationist-Ibn 'Arabian-Twelve synthesis; the latter, significantly, is here represented in the first place by Pythagoras and the (Neo) pythagoreans, called by him *fīthāghūrasīyyīn* or *āl-i Fīthāghūras*, together with Ps.-Aristotle (i.e., Plotinus) and Plato.⁶³ (Like Ibn Turka and other lettrists, Mīr Dāmād believes Pythagoras to be Solomon's contemporary and disciple – a common association in Arabic bio-bibliographical literature from the 3rd/9th century onward.⁶⁴) The camp of the Greek ancients is rounded out with citations of Nicomachus, Archytas of Tarentum, Anaximenes, Ptolemy, Homer and the Stoics (*riwāqīyya*). But it is only in the Islamic or Yemeni dispensation that metaphysical perfection may be attained. Ibn Sīnā is thus by far the most referenced authority in the *Jadhawāt*, more so than either Plato or Ps.-Aristotle; Mīr Dāmād's close identification with him is indicated by his habitual references to the Shaykh al-Ra'īs as 'my colleague' (*sharīk-i mā*) or 'my departed colleague' (*sharīk-i sālīf-i mā*), even 'my fellow in the vanguard of Muslim sages' (*sharīk-i mā dar ri'yāsāt-i ḥukamā-yi islām*).⁶⁵ He also strongly identifies with Fārābī, his 'earlier colleague in the promulgation and repair of Islamic philosophy' (*sharīk-i sābiq-i mā dar ta'līm u taṣḥīḥ-i falsafa-yi islāmī*).⁶⁶

A certain perennialist tension obtains in this Greek-Yemeni dichotomy, however. That is to say, Mīr Dāmād's schema, while ostensibly teleological and progressivist, remains committed to Greek precedent as model; Pythagoras

61 *Nibrās*, 77.

62 Rizvi, "Mīr Dāmād in India," 15: "Often he presents his argument by stating that he will first examine the 'Greek' philosophical position and then move on to the Yemeni one."

63 See e.g. *Jadhawāt*, 46, 47, 60, 62-5, 79, 105, 110, 115, 119-20, 134, 143, 147, 177, 179, 186, etc. Pythagoras and Plato in particular are routinely identified with theosis (*ilāhī, muta'allih*). Mīr Dāmād's primary source for Pythagorean doctrine is Shahrastānī's description thereof in the *K. al-Milal wa-l-niḥal*, quoting from it directly on 177-79; on 135, moreover, he counters Shahrastānī's objection to the Pythagorean concept of the correspondence of letters to reality. See Izdebska, "Pythagoreanism in Arabic," ch. 5.3.

64 *Jadhawāt*, 46; cf. Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 318, 325; Izdebska, "Pythagoreanism in Arabic."

65 *Jadhawāt*, 21-2, 27, 36, 65, 87, 102, 115, 122, 147, 162, 216, 221-2, 228, 247, 260, 266.

66 *Jadhawāt*, 65, 86.

and Plato in particular are *the* original theosized sages (sg. *ḥakīm-i muta'allih*). His Yemeni philosophy is thus both inherently superior to its Greek precursor and its faithful outworking, its actualization. Indeed, Mīr Dāmād asserts in the first 'firebrand' (*jadhwa*) or section of this work that the entirety of his large oeuvre is simply an explication of the *Theology of Aristotle*.⁶⁷ That a renewed interest in the *Uthūlūjīyā* is a hallmark of Safavid philosophy and the central driver of its Neoplatonic turn is widely recognized; Mīr Dāmād's assertion here may therefore be considered programmatic.⁶⁸

Ibn Sīnā's *New Year Treatise*

But to this key text Mīr Dāmād adds another: the *New Year Treatise* (*R. al-Nayrūzīyya*) of Ibn Sīnā.⁶⁹ While all of Ibn Sīnā's major works are clearly in view, Mīr Dāmād singles out this strange little treatise, which effectively summarizes the Avicennan system in Neopythagorean-lettrist terms by applying it to the quranic *muqatta'āt*, as his primary model and inspiration: it stands, for him, as the definitive Islamic answer to Pythagoras, the epitome of *Yemeni* Neopythagoreanism.⁷⁰ As such, between the *Jadhawāt* and the *Nibrās al-ḍiyā'* he in fact transcribes all three sections of the treatise in full, and his *Ta'wīl al-muqatta'āt* was almost certainly conceived of as an updated version of the same⁷¹ – all of which "suggests that the discovery of this epistle transformed Mīr Dāmād's Avicennian heritage, Avicenna's influence on him, and his own metaphysics as well."⁷²

He is not the first writer to cite the *R. al-Nayrūzīyya*, certainly, but he is far and away the most enthusiastic about its thesis. Several decades earlier, Ghiyāth al-Dīn Dashtakī had summarized in his tafsīr, *Dawning of Knowledge* (*Maṭla' al-'irfān*), an earlier summary of the treatise by an unnamed scholar (*ba'd al-muta'akhkhirīn*) – perhaps Dawānī or Khafrī? – as representing the

67 *Jadhawāt*, 15.

68 On the *Uthūlūjīyā* see e.g. Adamson, *The Arabic Plotinus*; on its Safavid revival see e.g. Rizvi, "(Neo)Platonism Revived"; Di Branco, "The 'Perfect King'."

69 Published in Ibn Sīnā, *Tis' rasā'il fi l-ḥikma wa-l-ṭabī'īyyāt*, 92-97.

70 For a summary of the *R. al-Nayrūzīyya* see Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 204-9. Mīr Dāmād does not seem to be aware of Maghrebi precedents such as Ibn Masarra's (d. 319/931) equally Neopythagorean *R. al-I'tibār* and *K. Khawāṣṣ al-ḥurūf*; see e.g. Ebstein, *Mysticism and Philosophy in al-Andalus*.

71 He quotes the first section of the *R. al-Nayrūzīyya* in the *Nibrās* (74-77), then directs the reader to the *Jadhawāt* and *Ta'wīl al-muqatta'āt* for a transcription and full discussion of sections two and three (*Jadhawāt*, 163-64 and 266-67 respectively).

72 Terrier, "The Wisdom of God," 121.

25th of 26 distinct explications of the *muqatta'āt*; but the Avicennan philosopher indicates that he finds their prognosticative potency in the form of *jafr* to be more salient than their philosophical interpretation by Ibn Sīnā, and the *R. al-Nayrūziyya* is otherwise unreferenced in his oeuvre.⁷³ (In other words, Dashtakī, a talented talismanist precisely in his role as philosopher, here favors lettrist practice over lettrist theory.) While he was presumably aware of Dashtakī's report, Mīr Dāmād rather cites Khafri as a follower of Ibn Sīnā's lettrist schema in his *Tafsīr āyat al-kursī*, and quotes in full the relevant section; therein the Shirazi philosopher summarizes the ancient doctrine associating letters, numbers and the various orders of existence.⁷⁴ Interestingly, Khafri credits this doctrine to the sages of India in particular.⁷⁵

There is, of course, the matter of authenticity. To my knowledge, the *New Year Treatise* was wholly ignored in lettrist sources until the early 10th/16th century: even the omnivorous Timurid polymath-compiler Ḥusayn Wā'iẓ Kāshifī (d. 910/1505) at his most lettrist only knows Ibn Sīnā's thoroughly

73 *Maṭla' al-'irfān fī tafsīr al-Qur'ān*, 353-56.

74 In the same passage Khafri also offers a lettrist analysis of the supreme Name *Allāh*.

75 *Jadhawāt*, 167-69; cf. 114, where Mīr Dāmād also credits the sages of India for their application of units 1-9 to the levels of existence. See Khafri, *Tafsīr āyat al-kursī*, 367-93; the section quoted is from the treatise's introduction (380-81). The *Tafsīr āyat al-kursī*, written after 1495 (it refers to the author's *Muntahā l-idrāk*), contains material in common with the author's *R. Marātib al-wujūd* (Saatchian, *Gottes Wesen – Gottes Wirken*, 42, 47). That Khafri was well aware of other lettrist forms of metaphysical speculation is confirmed in section 1.3, dealing with the question of God's knowledge, where he states (387):

This is the import of the verifiers' position that His knowingness (*'alimīyya*) refers to His status as Creator of all types of knowledge (*khallāq al-'ulūm*), and that the relation of His knowledge to the types of knowledge proper to contingent beings (*'ulūm al-mumkināt*) is comparable to the relation of the [alchemical] elixir to gold and silver; or, some say, the relation of the letters of the alphabet to the words they compose; or, some say, the relation of a date pit to a mature date palm; or, some say, the relation of a unit (*al-waḥda*) to the numbers; or, some say, the relation of the sea to its waves; or, some say, the relation of ink to written text; or, some say, the relation of water to those containers that can be made from ice. All these relations are relevant to that under discussion and clarify its various aspects.

Nor does Khafri ignore the practical applications of the verse's occult properties; in the introduction he provides basic astrological data in his discussion of the planetary spheres (376), and he dedicates the final section of the treatise to instances of quranic magic Muḥammad performed therewith, asserting that his purpose in composing it was to draw the attention of his royal dedicatee (identified only as *'ālī-ḥadrat man ayyadahu Llāhu ta'ālā bi-l-naṣr wa-l-zafar* (374) – presumably Shah Ismā'īl?) to the virtues of this verse and the supreme names of God it comprises in ensuring the continuance of his political power (393).

non-lettrist treatise *On Phonetics* (*R. fī Makhārīj al-ḥurūf*).⁷⁶ This fact alone would suggest the *R. al-Nayrūziyya* to be a later pseudepigraphical work.⁷⁷ And Mīr Dāmād himself observes that it does seem to contradict Ibn Sīnā's position in his other works, while embracing it regardless given its utility for his Neopythagoreanizing project.⁷⁸ At the same time, the biographer Ibn Abī Uṣaybi'a (d. 668/1270) already notes it as one of four works that Ibn Sīnā wrote on language (the other surviving work being his treatise on phonetics).⁷⁹ There are also other examples of Ibn Sīnā's treatises going unmarked by contemporaries due to the unsettled circumstances in which they were produced, only to resurface later – for instance, the *Feast of Sacrifice Treatise* (*R. al-Adḥawīyya*), dedicated to the same patron (the otherwise unknown al-Shaykh al-Amin Abū Bakr Muḥammad b. 'Ubayd), which is likely authentic.⁸⁰

As that may be, however, the authenticity of the *New Year Treatise* is immaterial; seemingly on the basis of Mīr Dāmād's lettrist writings alone, it exploded in popularity in Safavid Iran during the 11th/17th century, and became a common feature of Safavid philosophical anthologies.⁸¹ One 11th/17th-century instance in particular epitomizes the lettrist and/or antiquarian-perennialist tenor that pervaded Safavid intellectual culture: Tehran, MS Dānishgāh, Dānishkada-yi Ilāhiyyāt, 242B. Containing 87 texts or text excerpts, its strong Neoplatonic-Neopythagorean flavor is produced by the juxtaposition of ancient philosophers like Ps.-Aristotle (including the *Uthūlūjiyā*), Alexander of Aphrodisias and Ps.-Apollonius with Muslim philosophers like al-Kindī, (Ps.-)Fārābī (including the *Jam' bayn ra'yay al-ḥakīmāyn*), Ibn Sīnā (including,

76 Aka *R. fī Asbāb ḥudūth al-ḥurūf*. Kāshifī, a renowned lettrist author in his own day, penned the first explicitly lettrist exegesis of the Quran, *Jawāhir al-tafsīr* – which, naturally, quotes Ibn Turka; on this work see Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 261-67; ed. Jawād 'Abbāsī, Tehran: Mirāth-i Maktūb, 1379 Sh./2000.

77 Dimitri Gutas leaves its authenticity an open question (*Avicenna and the Aristotelian Tradition*, 508).

78 *Jadhawāt*, 102, 165. Here Mīr Dāmād compares his method (*uslūb, mashrab*) to that used by Ibn Sīnā in the fifth *namaṭ* of the *Ishārāt*, but states his preference for the model of the *R. al-Nayrūziyya* wherever it differs from the former. It would seem that the Safavid philosopher countenanced such internal contradictions by considering the *R. al-Nayrūziyya* to be Ibn Sīnā's challenge to late antique Neopythagoreanism and the fifth *namaṭ* of the *Ishārāt* his challenge to Sufism, each objective requiring different modes of attack.

79 'Umar, "Juhūd Ibn Sīnā fī l-Lughā wa-l-Aṣwāt," 116.

80 Gutas, *Avicenna and the Aristotelian Tradition*, 472-77.

81 At least 47 manuscript copies are extant in Iran alone; apart from two dated to the beginning of the 8th/14th century, all appear to have been produced between the 11th/17th and 13th/19th centuries (*DNA*, 10:914-16; cf. Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 205). For an analysis of such Safavid philosophical anthologies see Endress, "Philosophische Ein-Band-Bibliotheken."

of course, the *R. al-Nayrūziyya*), Suhrawardī, Ṭūsī, Quṭb al-Dīn Shīrāzī, Dawānī and Khafīrī. An occultist application of the same is then insisted upon by a number of alchemical texts from the Jābirian corpus, together with a work attributed to Jaʿfar al-Šādiq on *jafr*. In effect, this compendium constructs an intellectual continuum in which the most Imamic of the occult sciences (lettrism and alchemy) are considered essential components of philosophical practice, especially in a Shiʿizing-Neoplatonizing context.⁸²

It is therefore significant in this connection that Mīr Dāmād's reception of the Shaykh al-Ra'īs as a Neopythagorean coincided with the latter's transformation, in the Safavid and Ottoman realms both, into an authority on letter magic, exemplified by the attribution to him of the popular occultist manual *Spellcasters' Treasures* (*Kunūz al-muʿazzimīn*) – eloquent testimony as to the inextricability of Neopythagorean theory and magical practice.⁸³ (Even Ghazālī (d. 505/1111) was refashioned as a lettrist in the Safavid period, putative author of texts like the *The Protected Secret and Hidden Gem* (*al-Sirr al-maṣūn wa-l-jawhar al-maknūn*), on the comprehensive prognosticon of ʿAlī.⁸⁴) Equally tellingly, it also immediately preceded the 11th/17th-century explosion in popularity of al-Ḥāfiẓ Rajab al-Bursī's (d. after 813/1411) *Dawning of the Lights of Certain Knowledge: On the True Secrets of the Commander of the Faithful* (*Mashāriq anwār al-yaqīn fī ḥaqāʾiq asrār amīr al-muʾminīn*) – this despite the latter's semi-extremist positing, on a lettrist basis, of the Fourteen Infallibles as eternal cosmological principles and ʿAlī himself as just shy of divine. While Mīr Dāmād himself declined to cite this work, no doubt due to its problematic theological positions, preferring instead the philosophical rigor of Ibn Sīnā, Ibn Turka and Dawānī, it must be emphasized that al-Bursī therein simply *Twelverizes* the Neopythagoreanizing project of the contemporary New Brethren of Purity, which combined precisely Ibn ʿArabian letter metaphysics and Būnian letter magic.⁸⁵

82 Endress, "Philosophische Ein-Band-Bibliotheken," 35-56. Cf. the similar pairing of alchemy and kabbalah in contemporary Europe (Forshaw, "*Cabala Chymica* or *Chemia Cabalistica*").

83 See Jalāl al-Dīn Humāʾī's introduction to his edition of the text (Tehran: Anjuman-i Āsar-i Millī, 1331 Sh./1952). The Ottoman encyclopedist Taşköprüzāde too cites Ibn Sīnā as a noted authority on *sīmīyāʾ*, together with Suhrawardī (*Miftāḥ al-saʿāda wa-miṣbāḥ al-sīyāda*, 1:317).

84 Savage-Smith, "Magic and Islam," 66, cat. 21, no. 4; Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 246 n. 279, 274.

85 See Melvin-Koushki, "Safavid Twelver Lettrism"; Terrier, "Bursī"; al-Shaybī, *Tashayyuʿ u taṣawwuf*, 239-71; Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 218 n. 184. Crucially, al-Bursī would appear to be the first Shiʿi author to adopt the neat lettrist cosmology laid out by al-Būnī in the latter's (almost certainly authentic) *Subtle Pointers: On the Secrets of the Supernal*

Safavid Avicennism, in short, was unprecedentedly Neoplatonic *and* Neopythagorean in tenor; and some of the most prominent Safavid Shi'i scholars wielded Timurid-Aqquyunlu Sunni sources to transform both Aristotle and Ibn Sīnā, his greatest heir, into *lettrists*.

Ibn Turka's *On the Letters*

In the *Jadhawāt*, then, Mīr Dāmād asserts (Ps.-)Avicennan-Aristotelian lettrist Neopythagoreanism to be the golden chain binding Greek and Yemeni philosophy into a single, perennial tradition. But in this he was hardly innovative; as noted above, this assertion simply restates that made by Ibn Turka almost two centuries before. It is therefore little surprise to find that Mīr Dāmād's second primary lettrist source is Ibn Turka's treatise *On the Letters* (*R. Ḥurūf*), written in Shiraz in 1414 for the Timurid (occult) philosopher-king Iskandar Sulṭān (r. 812-17/1409-14), grandson of Temūr (r. 771-807/1370-1405) and main competitor with Shāhrukh (r. 811-50/1409-47) for control of Iran.⁸⁶ The *R. Ḥurūf* divides lettrists into two broad camps: the *ahl-i khawāṣṣ*, concerned with the practical applications of the science, identified with the Sufi-mage Aḥmad al-Būnī (d. btw. 622-30/1225-33); and the *ahl-i ḥaqāyiq*, concerned with its theoretical basis, identified with Ibn 'Arabī. The treatise provides for its royal patron a survey of the latter approach.⁸⁷ As with the *R. al-Nayrūziyya*, most surviving manuscript copies of this treatise were made in the Safavid realm; that it was seen as being essential for understanding the *Jadhawāt* is confirmed by their paired presence in at least one Safavid philosophical (and mystical-poetical)

Letters (*Laṭā'if al-ishārāt fī asrār al-ḥurūf al-'ulwīyyāt*), as Noah Gardiner's groundbreaking work on the Corpus Būnianam has shown. This the Iraqi lettrist-traditionist does in the introduction to his *Mashāriq*, which closely paraphrases a crucial programmatic passage in al-Būnī's treatise – further evidence that al-Bursī's sojourn in Cairo may well have coincided with that of Ibn Turka and/or al-Biṣṭāmī; see Gardiner, "Esotericism," 191-218.

86 While he lost this contest to his more conservative, Sunnizing uncle, Iskandar Sulṭān nevertheless stands as an early and important model for the new forms of universalist Islamicate kingship, explicitly predicated on occult-scientific principles, that were developed in the post-Mongol Persianate world; see Melvin-Koushki, "Islamicate Empire."

87 On this treatise see Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 88-90; an edition and translation are provided at 463-89. In it Ibn Turka refers to a major lettrist work in progress, likely to be identified with his *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*. He also refers to his important commentary on Ibn 'Arabī's *Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam*, unique among the host of commentaries on this text in its overtly lettrist approach, and completed in 1411, almost certainly for Iskandar Sulṭān as well (*ibid.*, 112-13).

anthology – which too emphasizes lettrist theory and lettrist practice in equal measure.⁸⁸

Most crucially, in this treatise Ibn Turka lays out his core doctrine of the three descending levels of the letter, which alone constellates the Chain of Being in its emanation from the One, and allows for the ascent and descent thereof: spiritual-mental (*ma'nawī lubābī*), spoken-oral (*lafẓī kalāmī*) and written-textual (*raqamī kitābī*). The letterforms' three loci of self-manifestation (*majlā*), which manifest the essence of every existent, are the heart (*qalb*), hearing (*samʿ*) and vision (*baṣar*) respectively.⁸⁹ It is highly significant in this context that prophecy (*nubuwwat*) is associated strictly with the spoken level of the letters, and sacral power or sainthood (*walāyat*), its actualization, with the written and mental both; Ibn Turka's innovation here is his bold assertion of the superiority of written to spoken, of *walāya* to *nubuwwa*, to the same degree that vision is superior to all other physical senses: for light (*nūr*), unlike sound, is incorruptible and universal, the directest aperture onto the One. This lettrist physics-metaphysics of light in turn explains 'Alī b. Abī Ṭālib's status as sole vector of *walāya* during the Islamic dispensation, for he was responsible for perfecting the written shapes of the 28 (or 29) Arabic letterforms, matrix of

88 This classic 11th/17th-century Safavid anthology, preserved as British Library MS Add. 16839, is nevertheless somewhat unusual in its heavy lettrist emphasis. Most significantly, this *majmū'a* conjuncts nine lettrist and other works by Ibn Turka (including, crucially, *R. Ḥurūf*, *R. Anjām*, *R. Nuqṭa* and *R. Shaqq-i qamar*) with Mīr Dāmād's *Jadhawāt* (and a second untitled treatise), together with sections from 'Alī Ṣafī Kāshif's lettrist summa *Ḥirz al-amān* (see n. 32 above; Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 271-80), a lettrist analysis of the name Muḥammad Bāqir by Mīrzā Qāsim Tūnī, the section on letter magic (*sīmīyā*) from the *Kanz al-'ulūm wa-l-durr al-manẓūm* of Muḥammad b. 'Alī b. Tūmart al-Andalusī and an extract from one of al-Būnī's lettrist works (*Khawāṣṣ dhikr al-asmā' wa-l-ḥurūf* – perhaps from the possibly pseudepigraphal *Khawāṣṣ asmā' Allāh al-ḥusnā*; see Gardiner, "Esotericism," passim). Among the authors represented on topics less lettrist, apart from Ibn Turka himself, are Ibn Sīnā (four works or excerpts), Ṭūsī (four works, including one on logic), Sayyid Sharif Jurjānī (untitled treatise), Dawānī (especially his *al-Zawra'*), Mīr Findiriskī (*R. Ṣinā'īyya*), Shaykh Bahā'ī (extracts from the *Kashkul*), Rajab-'Alī Tabrīzī (*R. Ishtirāk-i lafẓī-yi wujūd*), Muḥsin Fayḍ Kāshānī (untitled treatise), 'Abd al-Razzāq Kāshānī (two works) and Mullā Ṣadrā (*R. al-Taṣawwur wa-l-taṣdīq*). Sufi authorities include Bābā Afzal Kāshānī, Maḥmūd Shabistari, Jāmī, 'Abd Allāh Balyānī and Nasafi; poets include Ibn 'Arabī, 'Aṭṭār, Rūmī, Sa'dī, Ḥāfiz, Fuḍūlī, Jāmī, 'Abd al-Khālīq Ghijduwānī, Mīrzā Qāsim Tūnī, Fānī (Muḥammad Dihdār) and again Dawānī and Mīr Dāmād; and ancients include Aristotle and Hermes Trismegistus (see the partial table of contents in Rieu, Catalogue of the Persian Manuscripts, 2:833-35; my thanks to Sajjad Rizvi for providing me with images of this anthology). The *Jadhawāt* also prompted the association of Ibn Turka's lettrist works, including the *R. Ḥurūf*, with the *R. al-Nayrūziyya*, as in MS Majlis 10319, a philosophical anthology copied in the 13th/19th century.

89 *R. Ḥurūf*, 478-79.

the uncreated Quran, which alone allow for the transmission of words through time and space.⁹⁰

In other words, here Ibn Turka posits writing as simultaneously an exclusively 'Alid patrimony and primary vehicle of the *philosophia perennis*. At the same time, he holds number (*ʿadad*) – the mental-spiritual form of the letter – to represent the core of the prophetic revelation as actualized by the elite among the saints in every generation, including in the first place Pythagoras as foremost disciple of Solomon. Yet here too Ibn Turka designates this perennial doctrine a special patrimony of the House of the Prophet. As he states:

[T]he ancient sages held the science of number to be the alchemy in whose crucible all other sciences are produced and the elixir [productive] of all manner of rarities and marvels. The holy Imam Jaʿfar [al-Šādiq] (upon him be peace) also greatly vaunted this science, and those who cleave to the threshold of his *walāya* have penned numerous works on the subject.⁹¹

Ibn Turka is even more explicit on this point in his great summa of philosophical lettrism as Islamic Neopythagoreanism, the *Book of Inquiries* (*K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*), also begun for Iskandar Sulṭān and completed by 1420 (revised in 1425):

Behind this gate [i.e., the new lettrist theory here proposed] are the treasures of the Seal [Muḥammad]’s glory and the protected space of his intimacy which contain necklaces of precious jewels (*ʿuqūd farāʿid al-jawāhir*) and all else laid there in store. [Muḥammad] collected all this and provisioned therewith his son [ʿAlī b. Abī Ṭālib], the Seal of Sacral Power (*khātām al-walāya*) and standard-bearer of understanding and guidance.⁹² These necklaces (*ʿuqūd*) are numerical knottings (*al-ʿuqūd*

90 R. Ḥurūf, 481. Needless to say, lettrist theory is predicated on the doctrine of the uncreatedness of the Quran; Ibn Turka accordingly bemoans the contemporary popularity of Zamakhshari’s (d. 538/1144) *Kashshāf*, singling out his failure to recognize the intrinsic ontological majesty of the quranic letters for special censure (Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest,” 59, 54, 76, 116, 342). On the early modern Western valorization of the written word over the spoken more generally see Melvin-Koushki, “Of Islamic Grammatology”; idem, “*Tahqīq* vs. *Taqlīd*.”

91 R. Ḥurūf, 472. The alchemical references are here significant; Ibn Turka has in mind Jābir b. Ḥayyān in particular, whose Science of the Balance (*ʿilm al-mīzān*), the basis of Jābirian alchemy, is fundamentally lettrist in approach (see Melvin-Koushki, “The Quest,” 180–82, 353).

92 While Ibn Turka’s Sunni identity is not in doubt, it is testament to his lettrist-imamophilic proclivities that he breaks with Ibn ʿArabī’s identification of the *khātām al-walāya*

al-ʿadadiyya), the spiritual-intellectual form of the Book that was sent down from the highest Pen to the noble Tablet. Number, then, is the best means of acquiring sciences of great benefit and numerous as grains of sand, the primordial mine preserving the gems [at the core] of all the standard and mainstream sciences. [...] Let the researcher therefore set aside his various misconceptions and inquire into the matter of number, for it is the fountainhead of all the sciences, the quarry of all realities, an ocean of insights both manifest and occult.⁹³

Ibn Turka's distinctive brand of 'Alid-Pythagorean lettrism, as summarized in his *On the Letters*, was thus of manifest utility to Mīr Dāmād's own Twelverizing-Neopythagoreanizing project in the *Firebrands* – especially given the former's strongly imamophilic tenor, a feature absent from the *New Year Treatise*. But how does it relate to mainstream Avicennan-Illuminationist philosophy? Unlike the *R. al-Nayrūziyya*, which is concerned to simply Neopythagoreanize Avicennism, the *R. Hurūf* seeks to undercut it altogether. For there Ibn Turka advances the premise that drives his intellectual project as a whole: the faux-universal concepts of Avicennan-Illuminationist philosophical speculation notwithstanding, only the letter (*ḥarf*) encompasses all that is and is not, all that can and cannot be; it alone is the *coincidentia oppositorum*; hence lettrism is the only valid form of metaphysics. Or as he says:

[The letter] is a form sent down from the heaven of holiness that reveals all things – indeed, it also reveals things which have not entered into the circuit of existence, describing the manner of their [nonbeing]. For this reason the [concept of] letter must be considered more encompassing

al-muṭlaqa/al-ʿamma as Jesus, in this appearing to follow the Shiʿi mystical philosophers ʿAlī b. Sulaymān al-Baḥrānī (d. ca. 669/1271), Maytham b. Maytham al-Baḥrānī (d. 699/1300) and Ḥaydar ʿĀmulī (d. after 787/1385), who similarly awarded this status to ʿAlī as part of their project to synthesize Ibn ʿArabian theory with Twelver theology (see al-Oraibi, "Rationalism in the School of Bahrain," 333-34).

93 *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*, MS Majlis 10196, ff. 52a, 56b; Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 338, 344, 534. Note that *ʿadad*, translated here as 'number,' is also the standard term for arithmetic as part of the quadrivium. Ibn Turka is here updating the basic premise of the heavily Neopythagorean *Rasāʾil* of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafāʾ, which likewise open with the declaration that 'the science of number is the root of the sciences, the essence of wisdom, the foundation of knowledge and the [principal] element of all things' (*Rasāʾil*, 1:21-22; trans. Endress, "Mathematics and Philosophy in Medieval Islam," 133). Given their popularity in Iran and extreme usefulness for his purposes, it is curious that Mīr Dāmād does not appear to reference the *Rasāʾil* in either the *Jadhawāt* or the *Nibrās*; perhaps he felt that relying on Ibn Turka and Dawānī instead made any such reference superfluous.

than [such concepts as] existence (*wujūd*) or thing (*shay'*) or any other universal [category] that may be conceived. It encompasses all things, comprehending each in precisely the same way without being more inclined to one than another; the letter thus remains standing straight [and unitary] by virtue of its basic comprehensiveness. This is in contrast to everything else in existence, which [necessarily] inclines toward one of two opposing terms; thus existence is countered by nonexistence ('*adam*'), and likewise with thing, [countered by 'no-thing' (*lā-shay'*)], or contingency (*imkān*), [countered by necessity (*wujūb*)], or anything else that can be conceived.⁹⁴ [Referring to the letter's primordial straightness and singularity, says He:] *Praise belongs to God Who has sent down upon His servant the Book, and has not assigned unto it any crookedness* (Q 18:1).

That Ibn Turka sought in his challenge to philosophy to replace the Avicennans' *wujūd* and the Illuminationists' *māhiyya* and *nūr* with *ḥarf* in all respects is of signal importance for understanding the development of Islamic philosophy after Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī (d. 672/1274) in general and the engagement of Safavid philosophy with Timurid precedent in particular.⁹⁵ To allow for the long-overdue integration of Ibn Turka into the study of Safavid philosophy, I propose that we analyze his emanationist-creationist lettrist system as pivoting on the twin doctrines of *aṣālat al-ḥarf*, the ontological primacy of the letter, and *tashkīk al-ḥarf*, the graded modulation of the letter in written, verbal, mental and extra-mental form.⁹⁶ This, of course, has the advantage of allowing him to be read not just as source for Mīr Dāmād's essentialist Neopythagoreanism but also as precedent for Mullā Ṣadrā's radically existentialist system, which pivots rather on the doctrines of *aṣālat al-wujūd* and *tashkīk al-wujūd*, as Sajjad Rizvi has shown in his monograph on the subject. Therein he traces Mullā Ṣadrā's gradation schema back to Ṭūsī's commentary on Ibn Sīnā's *Pointers and Reminders* (*al-Ishārāt wa-l-tanbīhāt*), where these same four modes are identified as the basic levels of being; it thereafter became standard in philosophi-

94 *R. Ḥurūf*, 478. A primary proof-text for the letter as *coincidentia oppositorum* recurring throughout Ibn Turka's oeuvre is this line from Ibn al-Fārid's (d. 632/1235) *al-Tā'īyya al-kubrā*, l. 485/490: *ta'ānaqati l-aṭrāfu 'indī wa-nṭawā / bisāṭu l-siwā 'adl^{an} bi-ḥukmi l-sawīyyati*.

95 Again, this fact alone indicates the relatively minor importance of the *Tamhīd al-Qawā'id*, a non-lettrist Avicennan-Illuminationist-Ibn 'Arabian work on the topic of *wujūd muṭlaq*, within the context of Ibn Turka's larger lettrist project.

96 The Isfahani lettrist nowhere uses the terms *aṣālat al-ḥarf* and *tashkīk al-ḥarf*, though the connotation of each matches his position precisely; I suggest them here as useful heuristics. For an analysis of the same see Melvin-Koushki, "Of Islamic Grammatology."

cal treatments of the topic.⁹⁷ Ibn Turka was clearly well versed in the relevant texts; his doctrine of *tashkik al-ḥarf* should thus be considered an innovative critique and refinement of this model.

Of similar importance is the fact that Ibn Turkian lettrism represents the most sophisticated Islamicate formulation of the doctrine of the union of opposites (*majmaʿ al-aḍḍād, taʿānuq al-aṭrāf*) of the 9th/15th century – aka the *coincidentia oppositorum*, a Latin term coined, intriguingly, by Ibn Turka's later contemporary Nicholas of Cusa (d. 1464).⁹⁸ We know that Mir Dāmād, Shaykh Bahāʾī and other leading Safavid intellectuals were reading Ibn Turka's works; his invocation of this doctrine as damning indictment of the inadequacy of Avicennan-Illuminationist philosophy was therefore almost certainly a significant factor in the Safavid synthesizing transformation and expansion of that tradition, especially as culminating in Mullā Ṣadrā's 'transcendent philosophy' (*al-ḥikma al-mutaʿāliya*). Indeed, Corbin and Nasr see the *coincidentia opposi-*

97 Rizvi, *Mullā Ṣadrā*, 1. Rizvi translates from Ṭūsī's commentary on the *al-Ishārāt wa-l-tanbīhāt*, "Things possess being in extramental reality (*fī-l-a'yān*), being in the mind (*fī-l-adhḥān*), being in [linguistic] expression (*fī-l-ibāra*) and being in writing (*fī-l-kitāba*)," then notes that "Mullā Ṣadrā picks up on this fourfold scheme of the semantics of being in his logical epitome, *al-Tanqīḥ fi l-Mantiq* (The Re-examination of Logic): 'The being of a thing is extra-mental (*ʿaynī*), mental (*dhihnī*), uttered (*lafẓī*) or inscribed (*kutbī*)'" (Rizvi, *Mullā Ṣadrā*, 1-2). Ibn Sīnā himself appears to have been the first philosopher to propose the concept of the transcendental modulation of being, which he does in his *Mubāḥathāt* (Treiger, "Avicenna's Notion of Transcendental Modulation of Existence," 361-63). It should be noted, however, that by *tashkik al-wujūd* the Shaykh al-Raʾīs means *tashkik fī maḥmūd al-wujūd*, not *tashkik fī ḥaqīqat al-wujūd* as embraced by Mullā Ṣadrā and earlier developed by Suhrawardī (d. 587/1191) under the rubric of *tashkik al-nūr*; indeed, Mullā Ṣadrā may be said to have simply replaced *nūr* with *wujūd* in his own formulation and reinforced the proofs offered by Suhrawardī (Eshots, "The Principle of the Systematic Ambiguity of Existence"). Equally relevant to the present discussion is the fact that Mullā Ṣadrā posits *walāya* as the culminating point of the hierarchy of being immediately proximate to the One – but an adaptation of Ibn Turka's principle of *tashkik al-ḥarf* as the matrix of *walāya* (Rizvi, *Mullā Ṣadrā*, 129-30; Rizvi rather suggests Rajab al-Bursī as Mullā Ṣadrā's direct or indirect inspiration in this context, but I here propose Ibn Turka, as mediated by Mir Dāmād, as the more cogent and immediate model; see above).

98 Or as Joyce calls it, "andthisishis" (*FW* 177.33). On this doctrine in Ibn Turka's thought see Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 336; on its Latin cognate see Albertson, *Mathematical Theologies*. In his *Religion after Religion* (67-82), Steven Wasserstrom offers a wide-ranging discussion of the concept in the History of Religions movement and in the context of poetics, politics and ethics; as he shows, Gershom Scholem, Mircea Eliade and Henry Corbin were all great advocates of the principle, as was Carl Jung, who preferred the term *complexio oppositorum* (see e.g. his *Mysterium Coniunctionis*); and Freud attempted to explain the union of opposites in language and religion in his essay "The Antithetical Sense of Primal Words."

torum as pervading Safavid philosophy as a whole.⁹⁹ As the most aggressive and influential Iranian proponent of this doctrine before the Safavid conquest, then, Ibn Turka must be accounted as more than a mere placeholder between Ṭūsī and his Safavid heirs.

While the nature of its influence on Mullā Ṣadrā and other Safavid philosophers remains to be seen, Mīr Dāmād, for his part, openly embraces the signature Ibn Turkian doctrine of *tashkīk al-ḥarf* in the *Jadhawāt*. Taxonomizing the three modes of the letters in precisely the same manner, even to the extent of imitating Ibn Turka's adjective pairs for each (dubbing them *dhihnī-fikrī*, *lafẓī-qawli* and *raqamī-katbī* respectively),¹⁰⁰ our Safavid philosopher then proceeds to update the cosmological model provided in the *Uthūlūjīyā* on its basis. Mīr Dāmād first lauds its representation of the cosmos in the form of a circle (*dā'ira*) enclosing two chains (*silsila*) of descent into materiality (*hayūlā*) and ascent therefrom – manifestation (*badw*) and return (*ʿawd*); he then qualifies these chains as including two subchains, one vertical or longitudinal (*ṭūlī*) and one horizontal or latitudinal (*ʿarḍī*).¹⁰¹ Each level may be extended horizontally to incorporate various existents not connected causally, causal relations being only vertical. Man as microcosm contains both chains within himself, which allows him, uniquely, to ascend to the unitary Source. This return is accomplished solely through number-letter: for the totality of macrocosm and microcosm together constitute the Book of God, inscribed by the Pen or

99 Rizvi, "Isfahan School of Philosophy," *Elr*; idem, "Time and Creation," 715.

100 *Jadhawāt*, 134, 143–44. It should also be noted that Mīr Dāmād's discussion in the twelfth *jadhwa* of the letters' articulation points likewise draws on the *R. Ḥurūf* (152). Such a thoroughgoing Pythagorean does Mīr Dāmād consider himself, indeed, that he feels it his duty to defend the Greek sage against the critique of his source Shahrastānī (d. 548/1153), specifically by invoking Ibn Turka's tripartite division of the letter as cosmic category, then equating it to the following Pythagorean schema (*Jadhawāt*, 134):

Penetrating the depths, the Greek Pythagoras, theosized sage, thus ordered the levels and active properties of the three types of [mathematical] relationships: numerical, geometrical and harmonizing. He [further] took the numerical realm to reflect the lights of the realm of the intellect, indeed a ray from the holy lights, and the alphabetical realm to be body to the spirit that is the numerical.

101 *Jadhawāt*, 10–17; cf. Rizvi, *Mullā Ṣadrā*, 102–3. The longitudinal subchain of the chain of manifestation has five levels: 1) pure intellects (*ʿuqūl-i maḥḍa*), including in the first place the Universal Intellect; 2) celestial souls (*nufūs-i falakīyya*), including in the first place the Universal Soul; 3) natural souls (*nufūs-i muntabīʿa*), including the four natures and the elements; 4) bodily form (*ṣūrat-i jismīyya*); and 5) material beings (*hayūlīyyāt*). The longitudinal subchain of the chain of return also has five levels: 1) undelimited body (*jism-i muṭlaq*) and simple bodies of a species (*ajsām-i nawʿīyya-yi basīṭa*); 2) composite bodies (*ajsām-i murakkaba*); 3) the vegetal body (*jism-i nabātī*); 4) natural animal souls (*nufūs-i muntabīʿa-yi ḥayawānāt*); and 5) the human species (*nawʿ-i insān*).

Universal Intellect, with all existents being letters, words, sentences, verses and suras in that cosmic scripture.¹⁰² The divine Pen thus inscribed the forms of realities on the tablet of the Prophet, and he in turn imprinted the characters of knowledge and guidance on the tablet of humanity, whereupon the Intellects inscribed the letters of existence's essence in the great Book of Being. These Intellects are not limited to the usual nine, but (as with the Illuminationists) are according to the number of the fixed stars and proceed down through the celestial spheres until reaching the sphere of the Moon, where resides the Active Intellect, responsible for the effluxion of existence and its forms to the sublunar realm.¹⁰³

This Neoplatonic-Neopythagorean schema, although distinctively synthetic, is highly reminiscent of Ibn Turka's approach in his *Book of Inquiries*: its own centerpiece is a cosmological diagram dubbed the Ṭahawī Circle, similarly fivefold (units 1-9), which is supplemented by a threefold Yāsīnī Circle (decades 10-60).¹⁰⁴ That is to say, the Ṭahawī Circle is precisely the graphic representation of the lettrist doctrine, associated by Khafīrī, and following him Mīr Dāmād, with Indian sages in particular, applying the numbers 1 to 9 to the levels of being, of manifestation and return. Tellingly, in one of the *mīqāt* sections that follow the *jadhwas* (the *mīqāts* being largely devoted to explicating the properties of individual letters), Mīr Dāmād's discussion of a fivefold and a threefold circle is almost certainly in reference to those in the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ*.¹⁰⁵ No less than Ibn Turka, then, Mīr Dāmād shows himself to

102 *Jadhawāt*, 21-24.

103 *Ibid.*, 25-30.

104 Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 354-69. Note that the names of both diagrams refer to two instances of the quranic *muqatta'āt*, ṬH (Q 20:1) and YS (Q 36:1), respectively, together used metonymically to refer to the Quran or the Islamic creed as a whole (as in the "tribe of Ṭā-Hā and Yā-Sīn"). The first in particular "functions as a cosmological key encompassing the cosmos from the perspective of both absolute existence (*wujūd*) and engendered existence (*kawn*), and as such may be applied to cosmological data in numerous ways" (*ibid.*, 336). Significantly, Ibn Turka asserts his Ṭahawī Circle to be unprecedented in the lettrist tradition (*ibid.*, 356):

[N]one of the Verifiers have taken this view nor has it been suggested by any of the leading figures on the racecourse of perfection, those who open the locks on the gates of verification with the keys of their intuitions and unveilings; indeed, it is at variance [with all that has gone before].

105 *Jadhawāt*, 235-36. That Mīr Dāmād would have been familiar with Ibn Turka's *magnum opus* is suggested by the survival of a number of manuscript copies dating to the 10th/16th and 11th/17th centuries (Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 97), as well as the fact that Shaykh Bahā'ī refers to the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* in his *Kashkūl* (3:79), this on the basis of Mīr Ḥusayn Maybudī's (d. 910/1504) commentary on 'Alī's diwan, which likewise cites Ibn Turka's work to argue for the epistemological superiority of the concept of oneness to that of

hold lettrism to be an effective basis for metaphysics and cosmology, this by virtue of the correspondence between the revealed Quran (*Qur'ān-i tadwīnī*) and the Book of Creation (*Qur'ān-i takwīnī*). Or as Mīr Dāmād terms the Two Books (*al-kitābayn*): Existential (*al-wujūdī*) and Lettrist (*al-ḥarfī*).¹⁰⁶

So far lettrist theory; but what of lettrist praxis? Does Mīr Dāmād consider the magical harnessing of this correspondence between the Book of Being and the Book of Letter-Number for practical ends to be a natural application of philosophy? Certainly – like every other committed lettrist (Ibn 'Arabī himself excepted).¹⁰⁷ Immediately after his overview of the three letter modalities in *jadhwa* 11, for instance, Mīr Dāmād cites both *jafr* and medical letter magic as logical consequences and worthy applications of this system:

It is continuously narrated that the eighth of the lights of knowledge and wisdom (*thāmin anwār al-ilm wa-l-ḥikma*) and the infallible agents of purification (*aṣḥāb al-taḥīr wa-l-iṣma*), our lord and master Abū l-Ḥasan al-Riḍā (upon him be peace), wrote on the back of the charter of the Abbasid caliph Ma'mūn investing him as successor to the caliphate as follows: "The comprehensive prognosticon (*al-jāmi'a wa-l-jafr*)¹⁰⁸ indicates that this will not come to pass; I know not what he will do with me or with you all. *The judgment is God's alone: He relates the truth, and He is the best of deciders* (Q 6:57)."

The holy revelation *And We send down of the Quran that which is a healing and mercy to believers* (Q 17:82) likewise manifestly refers to the active properties (*khawāṣṣ*) of single letters and singular words and the effects of letter and nomial constructions. Just as every plant has a benefit and property peculiar to it, so too do the branches of the tree of speech and the tendrils of the vine of knowledge have properties and benefits – and these are beyond limit or compare. In the technical usage of the sons of reality (*abnā-yi ḥaqīqat*), the active properties of simple and compound

existence (*Sharḥ-i dōwān-i mansūb bi amīr al-mu'minīn 'Alī b. Abī Ṭālib*, 51). My thanks to Alexandra Dunietz for this reference; see her *The Cosmic Perils of Qadi Ḥusayn Maybudī*.

106 *Jadhawāt*, 161, 236.

107 See e.g. *al-Futūḥāt al-makkiyya*, 1:190 (translated in Gril, "The Science of Letters," in Ibn al-'Arabī, *The Meccan Revelations*, 2:124): "If I had not vowed never to provoke an effect (*athar*) via a letter, what marvels they would have seen!"

108 In the earliest Shī'i sources, the Calfskin (*al-jafr*) and the Comprehensive One (*al-jāmi'a*) seem to have been the names of two secret books in the possession of the Imams; on these and other such books see Amir-Moezzi, *Divine Guide*, 73-75; Modarressi, *Tradition and Survival*, 1:4-12, 17-20. In later centuries, however, these were conflated to describe a letter-divinatory text invented by 'Alī himself, the Comprehensive Prognosticon, in Persian *jafr-i jāmi'*.

letters and names, of verses and invocations, which correspond to medical simples and compounds, are termed spiritual medicine (*ṭibb-i rūḥānī*). It is said in this connection: "Lifting up one's voice with purity of intention in the hermitage of worship can undo the effects of the cycling heavens."¹⁰⁹

He then closes the *jadhwa* by referring the reader to *Awakenings* (*al-Īqāẓāt*), a work of his under production, for an explanation of the mechanics whereby lettrist invocations are answered and examples of efficacious prayer.¹¹⁰

Dawānī's *A Spiritual Boon*

Mīr Dāmād's personal letter-magical expertise aside, he here draws on a third lettrist source in support of his arguments: Dawānī's *A Spiritual Boon: On the Active Properties of Letters* (*Tuḥfa-yi rūḥānī fī khawāṣṣ al-ḥurūf*), a popular Persian treatise on astral-letter magic written in the mid- to late 1470s for Ghiyāth al-Dīn Muḥammad Shāh (r. 873-906/1469-1501), Khaljī sultan of central India, at the instance of the author's Indian student Jamāl al-Dīn Naṣr Allāh. This work cites Ibn Turka's similarly practical-theoretical *Query of Kings* (*R. Su'l al-mulūk*) – as does Mīr Dāmād himself.¹¹¹

Usefully for our purposes, the *Tuḥfa-yi rūḥānī* opens with a concise, standard-issue intellectual history of the science that is explicitly imamophilic-perennialist. It may be paraphrased as follows: The principles of this science were first laid down by such eminent ancient philosophers as Pythagoras, Apollonius of Tyana, Socrates, Plato and Aristotle, who were in turn dependent on the teachings of contemporary prophets, chief among them Solomon; they

109 *Jadhawāt*, 135-36. The source for this passage may be Ibn Turka's statements to the same effect in his *Conclusion* (*R. Anjām*) and *Query of Kings* (*R. Su'l al-mulūk*) (on these two treatises see Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 82-83, 119; the statements in question are at *ibid.*, 496, 509). Or as Mīr Dāmād states elsewhere (*Jadhawāt*, 91-92):

Every existent is governed by a holy Divine Name. The constituent letters [of each] correspond to medicinal roots and simples, while the words of quranic verses correspond to medicinal compounds and larger mixtures; [their] numerical values correspond to the constitution (*mizāj*) and form of the [human] species (*ṣūrat-i naw'ī*).

110 This work has been edited most recently by Ḥamid Nāji Iṣfahānī (Tehran: Mu'assasa-yi Pazhūhishī-yi Ḥikmat u Falsafa-yi Īrān, 1391 Sh./2012); see Bihbahānī, *Ḥakīm-i Astarābād*, 122.

111 See n. 109 above. For a summary of the *Tuḥfa-yi rūḥānī* see Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 248-55; an edition and translation is forthcoming in *idem*, *The Occult Science of Empire*. Mīr Dāmād calls it simply *R. Khawāṣṣ-i ḥurūf* (*Jadhawāt*, 146, 151, 156).

were especially focused on the mental or mathematical aspect of the letters. (Ps.-)Aristotle's *Book of Conjunctions* (*K. Iṣṭikākāt*) in particular developed the theory of astrological-lettrist correspondences, and other sages associated the 28 letters with the mansions of the Moon. This legacy passed to the community of Muḥammad, who was *given all the words*¹¹² and whose revelation enshrined all these secrets in an inimitable Book in summary form. But the secret to this science was entrusted solely to 'Alī b. Abī Ṭalīb, the particular Seal of Prophetic Vicegerency and Sacral Power (*khātām al-khilāfa wa-l-walāya al-muqayyada al-nabawīyya*), who invented the comprehensive prognosticon (*jafri-jāmi'*); this text passed down through the line of the Imams after him, particularly Ja'far al-Ṣādiq, who expounded its finer points (hence the near-identity of *jafri* and Ja'far).¹¹³ The science was then passed down through a line of sayyid scholars and Sufi saints, Ibn 'Arabī, the particular Seal of Muḥammadan Sainthood (*khātām al-walāya al-muqayyada al-muḥammadiyya*),¹¹⁴ chief among them; each had his own approach to this science but all discoursed on the properties of the letters, particularly their mental aspect. In the author's own day, Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī (d. 799/1397), famed alchemist-lettrist to the Mamluk sultan in Cairo, is considered to be its most influential exponent, and responsible for teaching the greatest lettrists – including in the first place Ibn Turka – of the 9th/15th century.¹¹⁵ This, then, is Mīr Dāmād's frame of reference, this the perennial golden chain, whose most recent Mamluk-Timurid-Aqquyunlu links are Akhlāṭī, Ibn Turka and Dawānī, our Safavid philosopher seeks to join in his own lettrist works.

Dawānī's status as conscious heir of Ibn Turkian lettrism is further confirmed by his authorship of *On the Declaration of Divine Unity* (*R. Tahlīliyya*), an explication of *lā ilāha illā Llāh* dedicated to Sultan Uzun Ḥasan Aqquyunlu (r. 861-82/1457-78) (and possibly his son and shortlived successor Sulṭān-Khalīl (r. 882-83/1478) as well),¹¹⁶ in which the author explicitly upholds Ibn Turka's

112 Muḥammad's assertion *Ūṭītu jawāmi' al-kalīm* is a favorite lettrist proof-text; this hadith is preserved in e.g. Muslim, *Ṣaḥīḥ*, *K. al-Masājīd wa-mawāḍi' al-ṣalāt*, bab 1, no. 1199; Aḥmad b. Ḥanbal, *Musnad*, *Musnad Abī Hurayra*, nos. 7521, 8266.

113 See n. 92 above.

114 Curiously, Dawānī here appears to be combining the Ibn 'Arabian doctrine of the particular and general Seals of Sainthood, the latter being Jesus and the former Ibn 'Arabī himself, with Ibn Turka's awarding of the Sealship to 'Alī alone.

115 Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 250-51. On Akhlāṭī as pivot of the New Brethren of Purity network, with Ibn Turka as his *khalīfa* to the east, see *ibid.*, 47-51; Binbaş, *Intellectual Networks*, ch. 4.

116 One manuscript copy (Tehran, MS Dānishgāh 1925/11, copied 1073/1663) features rather a dedication to Ḥabīb al-Dīn Muḥibb Allāh, grandson of Shāh Ni'mat Allāh Walī (d. 834/1431), founder of the eponymous Ni'matullāhī order – the latter, with Ibn Turka,

ranking of lettrism as queen of the sciences, epistemologically superior to, in ascending order, linguistics, philosophy and mystical theory.¹¹⁷ Significantly, both here and in *A Spiritual Boon* Dawānī embraces Ibn Turka's *tashkīk al-ḥarf* schema, thereby inspiring Mīr Dāmād's decision to do the same. The *R. Tahlīlīyya*, uniquely among the many works penned on the subject, would also seem to be specifically updating the *Subtleties in the Declarations of Divine Oneness in the Quran* (*Nikāt-i kalīmāt al-tawḥīd fī l-Qur'ān*) of Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī (d. 858/1454), the great Timurid dynastic historian, mathematician and litterateur-lettrist, Ibn Turka's student and closest friend. The latter work's two main sources are, naturally, Ibn 'Arabī's *Meccan Revelations* (*al-Futūḥāt al-makkiyya*) and Ibn Turka's *Book of Inquiries*; it rigorously analyzes the *tahlīl* through the lens of the Ṭahawī Circle and the Yāsīnī Circle both, and constitutes a Persian commentary on and expansive paraphrase of section nine of chapter 198 of the *Futūḥāt*, which addresses all 36 quranic instances of the same in sequential order.¹¹⁸ Where Yazdī's dense work closely follows its lettrist models, however, Dawānī's significantly more accessible offering uses the *tahlīl* to present a typology of the main scholarly and philosophical currents of his day – in much the same manner as Ibn Turka did in a number of similarly accessible treatises, some likewise written for members of the ruling elite.¹¹⁹ Dawānī's status as ideological mainstay to the Aqquyunlu Empire is thus here highly significant as well: for he was the first scholar to weaponize Yazdī's new brand

likewise a leading Ibn 'Arabian lettrist of the early Timurid era (Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 224-35).

- 117 Specifically, Dawānī here sets up a two-tiered comparison of levels of knowledge: the lettrist (*hurūfī*) mode of knowing is superior to the mystical (*shuhūdī*) as the philosophical (*'aqlī*) is to the linguistic (*lughawī*). For a summary of this treatise see Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 256-61; it was published as *Tahlīlīyya: Sharḥ-i lā ilāh illā Llāh*, edited by Firishta Furūzanda, Tehran: Kayhān, 1373 Sh./1994. Mīr Dāmād does not cite the *R. Tahlīlīyya*, but its currency around the turn of the 11th/17th century is suggested by the fact that Qāḍī Nūr Allāh Shūshtarī (d. 1019/1610) lists it as one of Dawānī's important Persian works, together with his *Tuḥfa-yi rūḥānī* (*Majālis al-mu'minīn*, 2:227-28); and at least 65 manuscript copies survive in Iran alone.
- 118 On this work see Binbaş, *Intellectual Networks*, 85, 99-101 (its two sources are not here identified).
- 119 These include in the first place the latter's *On the Splitting of the Moon and the Last Hour* (*R. Shaqq-i qamar u bayān-i sāt*), which rather analyzes a quranic verse according to seven distinct scholarly-philosophical modes in epistemologically ascending order, from literalist traditionism to lettrism (for an analysis and translation see Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," ch. 6, and 454-62).

of ornate Neopythagorean historiography to argue, in strictly lettrist terms, for the imperial supremacy of the Uzun Ḥasanid state within Islamdom.¹²⁰

Despite the fact that, predictably, Dawānī has yet to be approached as a lettrist in modern scholarship, Mīr Dāmād's reception of him as such indicates him to be a pivotal figure in the transmission of both lettrist theory and lettrist practice to his Safavid heirs. In particular, (Ps.-)Aristotle's reputation among some Safavid scholars as an authority on astrology and letter magic may be attributed in the main to Mīr Dāmād's approving references to the pseudopigraphal *Book of Conjunctions*, based exclusively on Dawānī's summary of the same.¹²¹ (Similarly, Dawānī appears to have been primarily responsible for bringing the *Uthūlūjīyā* itself, the basis for Mīr Dāmād's philosophy as a whole, back into mainstream philosophical use in Iran.¹²²) Nor was Mīr Dāmād alone in his estimation; most tellingly, his student Ishkawārī, author of the seminal antiquarianist-perennialist intellectual history *Hearts' Beloved* (*Maḥbūb al-qulūb*), saw fit to devote fully half of his entry on Dawānī to an analysis of the Shirazi philosopher's lettrist defense in verse of 'Alī's ontological supremacy, incarnating *īmān* to the same degree Muḥammad does *islām*, Occult to Muḥammad's Manifest:

Perfection's Sun is the Prophet – the Moon, his *walī*;
Islam is Muḥammad – Faith is 'Alī.
If you seek proof (*bayyina*) of this
look but to the *bayyināt*¹²³ of their names.¹²⁴

120 Dawānī's role as lettrist imperial ideologue is noted in Woods, *The Aqquyunlu*, 102, 145; for a study of the same see Melvin-Koushki, *The Occult Science of Empire*. On Ibn Turkian-Yazdian Neopythagorean-monist historiography as a pointed retort to Ibn Khaldūn's dualist scheme in particular see Melvin-Koushki, "In Defense of Geomancy."

121 *Jadhawāt*, 146-47.

122 He cites it repeatedly, for example, in his first *ḥāshiya* on Qūshchī's (d. 879/1474) commentary on Ṭūsī's *Tajrīd al-I'tiqād*, and it burgeoned in popularity from there (Pourjavady and Schmidtke, "An Eastern Renaissance?" 258). Cf. Di Branco's argument that such apparent neglect of the *Uthūlūjīyā* after Suhrawardī is more an artifact of the loss of pre-Safavid manuscripts of this seminal text to age and destruction ("The 'Perfect King'").

123 This refers to the standard lettrist procedure of *taksīr*, or separating the letters of a name or word and writing out the letternames in full (e.g., Aḥmad → AḤMD → ALFḤAMMYMDAL); the term *zubur* denotes the first letters in the full letternames (e.g., the A in ALF) and *bayyināt* the remaining letters (e.g., LF in ALF), both being derived from the prooftext Q 16:44. In this case the *bayyināt* of Muḥammad (MḤMD → YMAYMAL) and 'Alī (LY → YNAMA) are numerically – and hence ontologically – equivalent to *islām* (ASLAM = 132) and *īmān* (AYMAN = 102) respectively.

124 *Maḥbūb al-qulūb*, 2:465-67; the same *dūbayt* is cited in Sām Mīrzā Ṣafawī, *Tadhkira-yi tuḥfa-yi sāmī*, 77, and discussed in Shūshtarī, *Majālis al-mu'minīn*, 2:224-25. On the first

This is not to suggest that the sage of Astarabad is uncritically accepting of his lettrist sources; he freely critiques specific points made by Ibn Sīnā, Ibn Turka and Dawānī alike. He begs to differ, for instance, with the analysis of the letter *M* given in the *R. al-Nayrūziyya*, and quibbles with Ibn Turka on the matter of the *Ṣ*.¹²⁵ Mīr Dāmād's criticism of Dawānī is more pointed: he catches an elementary mistake made by his Shirazi predecessor as to the number of dotted vs. undotted letters, and picks apart at some length Dawānī's discussion of speech as the product of friction between knowledge and power (a theory ascribed by Dawānī to certain unnamed *aṣḥāb-i kashf u taḥqīq*), dismissing it as incompatible with basic philosophical principles.¹²⁶ Yet such criticisms are minor, and simply reflect Mīr Dāmād's close engagement with these lettrist thinkers and full acceptance of their larger projects.¹²⁷

Perennialist Neopythagoreanism and Mamluk-Timurid-Aqquyunlu-Safavid Sunni-Shi'i Continuity

Mīr Dāmād's Yemeni philosophy, then, as presented in the *Jadhawāt*, definitively *Islamicizes* and *Twelverizes* Pythagoras (along with Plato and Plotinus) by embracing the brand of imamophilic Neopythagorean lettrism propounded by (Ps.-)Ibn Sīnā, Ibn Turka and Dawānī: the *philosophia perennis*.¹²⁸ In the

work see Terrier, "Le *Maḥbūb al-qulūb* de Quṭb al-Dīn Ashkevarī"; idem, *Histoire de la sagesse*. The first half of Ishkawarī's entry is devoted, naturally, to establishing Dawānī's imamophilia. While Ishkawarī's Twelverization of Dawānī obviously reflects Safavid norms and needs more than Timurid-Aqquyunlu, it must be emphasized that 9th/15th-century persophone lettrists, including Dawānī, were openly devoted to 'Alī and Ja'far al-Ṣādiq as fountainheads of all occult knowledge in Islam. Among other things, this suggests that Dawānī's infamously "Twelveresque" treatise, *Nūr al-hidāya*, written at the end of the author's life during the Safavid conquest of Iran, was not simply a mercenary attempt to placate Shah Ismā'īl, as is usually assumed, but also a sincere expression of the philosopher's imamophilic outlook (relying on Ibn 'Arabi to this end).

125 *Jadhawāt*, 139-40, 221, 247.

126 *Ibid.*, 151-52, 156-58.

127 Significantly, neither Ibn Turka nor Dawānī is cited by name (the former he calls *fāḍilī az afāḍil-i aṣḥāb-i dhawq* (*ibid.*, 139, 153), the latter he calls *ba'dī az muta'akhhirīn-i afāḍil* (*ibid.*, 146, 151, 156)) – an index precisely of the currency of their lettrist treatises. The oldest manuscript copy of the *Jadhawāt*, however, MS Majlis 2091, copied during the author's lifetime, does feature his occasional comments in the margins; there he gives their names (lvi).

128 That the same processes define Safavid perennialist philosophy more broadly is shown in Terrier, "La figure de Pythagore."

tenth *jadhwa* he explicitly declares it the foundation of his own philosophical system, and indeed of the philosophical quest throughout history:

In sum: The greatest of theosized sages and divinized scholars (*a'āzim-i ḥukamā-yi ilāhiyyīn u afākhīr-i 'ulamā-yi rabbāniyyīn*) (who enjoy the victuals of truth and the flavors of precise knowledge with the sense of taste that is their holy faculty of intuition (*ḥads*)) all agree on the fact that the levels of the engendered realms correspond to those of the realm of number and the relations that obtain between engendered beings (*nisab-i kawniyya*) correspond to numerical relationships (*munāsabāt-i 'adadiyya*), and that the formation of such relations and the combination of the active properties of the realm of number – the shadows of those marriages (*izdiwājāt*) contracted by passions and impassionings (*ashwāq u tashwīqāt*) and the traces of those embracings of the dawning lights and luminosities of the realm of the intellect – constitute the mirror and measure of the realities of engendered ipseities (*ḥaqāyiq-i huwiyyāt-i kawn*) and the scale and benchmark for the levels of engendered beings (*marātib-i kawniyyāt-i wujūd*).¹²⁹

In the eleventh *jadhwa* he restates this summary with uncharacteristic clarity, leaving us in no doubt as to his lettrist bona fides:

In sum: The realm of the letter corresponds to that of number, and the realm of number corresponds to that of engendered existence (*kawn*); and the relationships (*munāsabāt*) that obtain in the realm of letter correspond to those that obtain in the realm of number, which in turn correspond to the commixtures (*mumāzajāt, mukhālaṭāt*) that constitute the realm of engendered existence.¹³⁰

A more succinct summary of early modern Neopythagoreanism cannot be imagined. Thus Mīr Dāmād, like many Western thinkers before and after him, Muslim, Jewish and Christian, fully subscribes to the theory of correspondence between number, letter and engendered being – the mechanism that makes all occult-scientific operations possible.

129 *Jadhawāt*, 119.

130 *Ibid.*, 133–34.

Unlike modern researchers, moreover, “disenchanted” children of the “Enlightenment” all,¹³¹ he does not confine his metaphysical speculations to the bounds of his own mind, but affirms the responsibility of philosophers to proactively heal the world and build their societies through letter-magical practice. The Twelve Imams are here the model, guides to humanity through their mastery of *jafr*:

When a person is divinely enabled to perceive all the special correspondences between and active properties of the levels of that realm [of the letter], the states of all engendered beings and the frequency and quality of past and future events will, by God’s leave, be revealed to him. This was the case with the holy and ennobled soul of the Gate to the City of Knowledge (*bāb madīnat al-‘ilm*) and Abode of the Midian of Wisdom (*dār Madyan al-ḥikma*), denizen of the Ṭayba¹³² of certainty and scion of the Ka’ba of infallibility, the Commander of the Faithful ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib, together with his pure sons and legatees, including Abū Ja’far al-Bāqir, Abū ‘Abd Allāh al-Šādiq, Abū l-Ḥasan al-Riḍā and the rest of our infallible lords (*sādātīnā l-ma’šūmīn*) (God’s blessings and peace be upon him and them all).¹³³

Nor should such declarations, while obviously Twelver in tenor, be reflexively construed as evidence that the Safavid conquest of Iran marked a cultural rupture with Mamluk, Timurid, Aqqyunlu or even Ottoman precedent; this passage – including its insistence on Imamic *‘isma* – faithfully reiterates the

131 On the purely ideological nature of both terms see e.g. Josephson-Storm, *The Myth of Disenchantment*.

132 I.e., Medina.

133 *Jadhawāt*, 120. Mastery of *jafr*, of course, presupposes mastery of arithmetic; hence ‘Alī’s status in particular as a mathematical genius. Mīr Dāmād thus transmits immediately after the above passage this report (ibid., 120–21):

There was no arithmetician more dextrous than ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib (upon him be peace) (*kāna [...] aḥṣab al-nās*). It is said that a Jew once came to ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib and challenged him: “‘Alī! Tell me what number can be divided into equal halves, thirds, fourths, fifths, sixths, sevenths, eighths, ninths and tenths, without remainder?” Said ‘Alī, “If I tell you, will you become Muslim?” “Yes,” he replied. Said [‘Alī], “Multiply the number of your Fridays in your month with the days of your month multiplied by [the days of] your year – this will give the desired result.” [The Jew] did so and found it correct, and so converted to Islam.

Mīr Dāmād then quotes his explanation of this operation as given in his *Sharḥ taqdimat Taqwīm al-īmān*. Tellingly, his student Ishkawārī cites the same episode in the introduction to his own *Laṭāyif al-ḥisāb* (12–13; see n. 150 below).

consensus of the leading Sunni lettrists of the 9th/15th century.¹³⁴ The Safavid reception of Ibn Turkian-Dawānīan lettrism, in short, represents a confessionalist *coincidentia oppositorum*: it powerfully furthered the *Shi'ization* of Iran – yet guaranteed smooth intellectual continuity with Sunni precedent. For Mīr Dāmād, as for Ibn Turka and Dawānī, the Imams and the ancients stand equal as vectors of *walāya*, engine of theosis, and lettrism an especially effective means of accessing and harnessing their sacral power for the strengthening of state and society.

Lettrist praxis, that is, was in the early modern Persianate world an inherently *imperialist* undertaking, in the Safavid, Mughal and Ottoman Empires alike.¹³⁵ Indeed, some sources suggest that Shah ‘Abbās may well have been jealous of Mīr Dāmād’s popular influence – a popularity sustained not only by his abstruse philosophizing, but also by his status as a state-building occultist and jurist. It is not impossible that the latter entertained dreams of philosopher-kingship himself.¹³⁶ Among other factors, that Mīr Dāmād is encomionized by the contemporary Safavid historian Iskandar Beg Munshī (d. ca. 1042/1633) in terms that immediately recall the claims of Iskandar Sulṭān, Ibn Turka’s first and most important Timurid patron and self-professed second Alexander, is here telling:

He encompasses all modes of physical and spiritual perfection (*jāmi’-i kamālāt-i šūrī u ma’nawī*) and reveals intricacies both conceptual and natural (*kāshif-i daqāyiq-i anfusī u āfāqī*), having attained the highest level of mastery of most of the philosophical sciences and mathematical occult arts (*ulūm-i hikmiyyāt u funūn-i gharība-yi riyādī*), together with jurisprudence, tafsir and hadith....¹³⁷

That the “mathematical occult arts” here refer in the first place to Neopythagorean lettrism should now go without saying. As that may be, the example of Mīr Dāmād as imperial philosopher-lettrist is essential to any understanding of the paradox that defines Safavid imperialism specifically and early modern Persianate instances thereof generally, whereby “medieval”

134 Again, Dawānī is quite explicit in his defense of imamic infallibility in his *Nūr al-hidāya* (105-28); see n. 124 above.

135 On this theme see Melvin-Koushki, *The Occult Science of Empire*.

136 Terrier, “Mīr Dāmād,” 131.

137 *Tārīkh-i ‘ālam-ārā-yi ‘Abbāsī*, 1:146-47. Cf. Iskandar Sulṭān’s self-presentation in his preface to a manual of mathematical astronomy, *Jāmi’-i sulṭānī*, possibly his own work as well; see Melvin-Koushki, “Islamicate Empire,” 360-61.

forms of “spirituality” constructed and sustained distinctively “modern” forms of political and legal authority.¹³⁸

As for theory: to thinkers like Ibn Turka and Dawānī, the central philosophical virtue of lettrism is its effective reconciliation of the otherwise irreconcilable Neoplatonic-Aristotelian emanationist and quranic accounts of creation, its unparalleled ability to marry Greek philosophy to its Islamic actualization.¹³⁹ This, of course, is the quest central to Mīr Dāmād’s project.¹⁴⁰ While it is probably going too far to declare *ḥudūth dahrī* to be a specifically lettrist concept, the fact remains that our Astarabadi sage-mage was monomaniacally focused on marrying the opposites of Greek and Islamic time – by means, at least in part, of letter theory and letter magic.¹⁴¹ For why would Mīr Dāmād – an emphatically Illuminationist philosopher – reject the model of Suhrawardī himself, who too was famed as a sage and a mage?¹⁴²

138 Terrier, “Mīr Dāmād,” 127; on the same medieval-modern tension more broadly see Melvin-Koushki, “*Tahqīq* vs. *Taqlīd*.”

139 In purely practical, gematrical terms, indeed, Arabic lent itself rather more readily to the peculiarly Western “nature-scriptural consciousness” than Greek and then Hebrew, neither of whose alphabets have enough letters to fully represent units, tens and hundreds, up to one thousand.

140 As Rizvi notes (“*al-Qabasāt*,” 438): “If ever there was a philosopher in the postclassical period obsessed with a single problem, it was Mīr Dāmād and the problem of the incipience of the cosmos....”

141 Cf. Mīr Dāmād’s discussion of the Pythagorean concept of oneness (*waḥda*) as summarized by Shahrastānī (*Jadhawāt*, 46-47; the same discussion occurs in his *Taqwīm al-īmān*, 285-86; see Terrier, “La représentation de la sagesse grecque,” 308-9; idem, “La figure de Pythagore”):

[The Pythagorean sages (*fithāghūrasīyyīn-i ḥukamā*)] also hold that oneness as such falls into [five] categories: oneness before perpetuity (*qabl al-dahr*), oneness with perpetuity (*ma’ al-dahr*), oneness after perpetuity (*ba’d al-dahr*), oneness before time (*qabl al-zamān*) and oneness with time (*ma’ al-zamān*). Now oneness before perpetuity is the oneness of the Creator Most High; oneness with perpetuity is the oneness of the First Intellect (*al-‘aql al-awwal*); oneness after perpetuity is the oneness of the Soul (*al-naḥs*); oneness with time is the oneness of the elements and the existents they compose (*al-‘anāšir wa-l-murakkabāt*).

On Mīr Dāmād’s philosophical quranic hermeneutics more generally, and his rather audacious invocation of the concept of *dahr* as interpretive key to this end, see Terrier, “Aspects d’une lecture philosophique.”

142 While less explicit as to the nature of his occult-scientific practice than his early modern heirs, Suhrawardī, as a good Neoplatonist and perennialist, nevertheless cuts a magical, theurgic figure in contemporary and later sources. See especially Walbridge, *The Leaven of the Ancients*, ch. 5 (on the place of Pythagoras in Illuminationist philosophy see ch. 6); Piṭṭak, “Between Philosophy, Mysticism and Magic.”

Conclusion

Much further research will need to be done before we can begin to weave philosophical lettrism back into the complex tapestry, now tattered, that is Safavid imperial philosophy. Even at this early stage, however, the conclusion is inescapable: intellectual, social and political historians of the period can no longer afford to turn a blind, occultophobic eye to the Mamluk-Timurid-Aqquyunlu science of letters, simultaneously core of the Ibn 'Arabian legacy and preferred avenue of philosophical practice in Safavid Iran, or disappear imperial letter-magicking into the apolitical categories of esotericism or mysticism. (Particularly pernicious is the entrenched assumption in the literature that the more flamboyant Ḥurūfiyya are representative of Persianate lettrism, rather than a strictly marginal Sufi movement execrated by Ibn Turka and his colleagues.¹⁴³) Failing that, the very existence of texts like Mīr Dāmād's *Firebrands* must remain inexplicable, and their seminal status seem bizarre – hence the polite silence in most of the scholarship surrounding our philosopher's lettrist works to date.¹⁴⁴

Yet that silence would seem to be justified by a similar silence in Mīr Dāmād's other, more "mainstream" works on metaphysics or jurisprudence, which, it is true, give little evidence for the lettrist commitments of their author. The same principle applies to the oeuvres of Dawānī, Khafī, Shaykh Bahā' and other leading thinkers (and doers) of the early modern Persian cosmopolis; their fellow metaphysician Ibn Turka is unusual in his singleminded championing of lettrism in a majority of his major and minor works. But to cite this as justification for the extreme marginalization of Magic in current Islamicate intellectual historiography generally and the study of Mīr Dāmād specifically is to ignore the basic fact that genre boundaries in Arabic and Persian letters are usually quite strong, and scholars routinely wore many hats – including the star-dappled cap of the court wizard.¹⁴⁵ We moderns must be more

143 Rasūl Ja'fariyān suggests, for instance, that Mīr Dāmād's Astarabadi stemming must have entailed his familiarity with Ḥurūfi doctrines, given the same stemming of Faḍl Allāh Astarābādī (d. ca. 796/1394), founder of the movement, and given the persistence of Ḥurūfi and especially Nuḳṭawī proselytizing in the region (*Maqālāt-i tārikhi*, 12:331, 333, 336). While this was doubtlessly the case, it cannot be presumed to have been his primary source of inspiration; Mīr Dāmād's sources, it must be emphasized, are exclusively of the high lettrist variety, which is to say expressly anti-Ḥurūfi. On this sharp polemical distinction drawn by Ibn Turka and his fellow lettrists see Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," ch. 8; Fleischer, "Ancient Wisdom."

144 Again, a rare exception is Terrier, "Wisdom of God"; cf. Rizvi, "Philosophy as a Way of Life," 42-43, which makes the same theurgic point with respect to Mullā Ṣadrā.

145 My thanks to Devin Stewart for this observation.

vigilant lest we backproject the extreme balkanization and ghettoization of the Euro-American academy – wherein Science and Religion, now implacable enemies, have nevertheless conspired to force out Magic – onto our early modern scholarly actors. Their career paths, while equally treacherous, were far less constricted and discipline-bound than our own; and this relative conceptual freedom allowed leading philosophers like Mīr Dāmād to treat Magic as simply good Science and good Religion alike – and a scientific-religious basis for Empire.

To understand occult science as applied philosophy, then, we need only shift to another genre, that of classifications of the sciences (sg. *taṣnīf al-ʿulūm*). In all the major Arabic and Persian instances of that genre produced between the 4th/10th and 11th/17th centuries, the occult sciences constitute *at least half* of the natural sciences as a rule, from astrology and alchemy to medicine and even agriculture. In Persian encyclopedias, moreover, but not Arabic, they were increasingly reclassified as mathematical sciences as a means of asserting their scientific legitimacy in the face of centuries of anti-occultist polemic – a process that coincided, not surprisingly, with the renaissance of Neopythagoreanism here in view. That the current historiography of Islamicate science is wildly out of proportion to both these classifications and the surviving archive merely testifies to our own fear of Magic.¹⁴⁶ For Mīr Dāmād and his Neopythagoreanizing colleagues, by contrast, there was clearly no question. Lettrism is just good physics – and good metaphysics; that letter magic and letter divination do in fact work is the surest proof for the validity of Neoplatonic cosmology. Likewise, that our Safavid cosmologists each thought it appropriate to write a few works on lettrism (and geomancy in the case of Khafri) is hardly proof of their *disregard* for occult science, but rather surest index of their lived, sociopolitical identity as sage-mage architects of the world.

Within the confines of Mīr Dāmād's oeuvre itself, the task is therefore now to reconcile those programmatic statements in the *Jadhawāt* and elsewhere as to the centrality of lettrist Neopythagoreanism to his life's project with his more celebrated, genre-appropriate contributions to Safavid philosophy and theology.¹⁴⁷ How does its deployment in the *Nibrās* solve the thorny problem

¹⁴⁶ These encyclopedias are surveyed in Melvin-Koushki, "Powers of One." It bears noting in this context that Dawānī's own introductory survey of ten sciences, *Unmūdhaj al-ʿulūm*, is not concerned with matters occult, apart from medicine (Pourjavady, *Philosophy*, 12-13).

¹⁴⁷ The *Jadhawāt*, Mīr Dāmād's only major work in Persian and rather more accessible than the bulk of his ornate oeuvre, refers to 12 of the author's other major and minor works in support of various points (xlvi-lv): *Taqwīm al-īmān* (12x), *al-Rawāshih al-samāwiyya* (6x), *al-Taqdīsāt* (6x), *al-Ufuq al-mubīn* (5x), *al-Īmādāt wa-l-tashrīqāt* (5x), *Sidrat al-muntahā* (2x) and *al-Īqāzāt*, *al-Sab' al-shidād*, *Sharḥ taqdimat Taqwīm al-īmān*, *al-Širāṭ al-mustaḳīm*,

of *badā'*, or render it a genuine philosophical category?¹⁴⁸ Can his signature doctrine of perpetual creation be understood in lettrist terms? How does his insistent identification in the *Jadhawāt* of lettrism as the proper province of theosized sages (*ḥukamā-yi ilāhiyyīn*, *ʿuqalā-yi mutaʿallihīn*) jibe with the rest of his oeuvre on the one hand and his pivotal role in Safavid society on the other? To what extent was the unprecedentedly massive Safavid Shiʿi hadith industry, inaugurated by Mīr Dāmād and his peers, motivated by a literalist-lettrist outlook?¹⁴⁹

And what of his students? Did they politely ignore his lettrist ravings? Certainly not: we know that Quṭb al-Dīn Ishkawārī, for instance, a prominent intellectual historian and *shaykh al-islām* of Lahijan, carried on his teacher's lettrist project;¹⁵⁰ Mīr Dāmād's son-in-law and most devoted student, Mīr Sayyid Aḥmad al-ʿAlawī al-ʿĀmilī, presumably did so as well.¹⁵¹ We further know

Uyūn al-masāʾil and *Taʿwīl al-muqattaʿāt* once each. Such a high degree of intertextuality suggests it to be a key to his oeuvre as a whole; note that *al-Širāṭ al-mustaqīm*, *al-Ufuq al-mubīn* and *al-Imādāt wa-l-tashrīqāt* in particular treat, like his more famous *al-Qabasāt*, of the topic of *ḥudūth dahri*. Indeed, it is highly suggestive in this context that the opening line of the *Jadhawāt*'s proem uses *qabasāt* and *jadhawāt* as a synonymous term pair (1).

148 *Nibrās*, 80; for a preliminary but convincing answer to this question see Terrier, "The Wisdom of God."

149 Ibn Turka argues for a literalism-lettrism epistemological cycle of ascent and return, whereby the self-divinizing sage ascends to lettrism from literalism via dialectical theology, Avicennan philosophy, Illuminationist philosophy and Sufi practice, then back to literalism – to the text itself (Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 315–28). On Safavid perennialist antiquarianism as expressive of the *taḥqīq* ethos definitive of Western early modernity more generally, see Melvin-Koushki, "*Taḥqīq* vs. *Taqlīd*."

150 The sections on Adam and Pythagoras in his *Maḥbūb al-qulūb*, most notably, are in places openly lettrist (1:135–57, 208–36; for selected translations and analysis see Terrier, "La représentation de la sagesse grecque"; idem, *Histoire de la sagesse*). Ishkawārī also wrote a treatise on mathematics, *Laṭāʾif al-ḥisāb*, which explicitly presents lettrism as the discipline's most immediate application, especially for scholars of a Twelver persuasion: the introduction holds up ʿAlī as mathematical exemplar (12–13), and the *khātima* opens with a lettrist analysis of the names of Muḥammad and the Twelve Imams (all being ontologically intrinsic to Q 33:33; 67–70), treats of finger counting (*ʿuqūd-i aṣābi*) and fraction of numeration (*taksīr*), then closes with a long section on logographs (sg. *muʿammā*) and riddles (sg. *luḡh*) and their solutions which prominently features Shaykh Bahāʾī as master of this art – a mainstay of lettrist practice from Ibn Turka onward (74–92; Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 382–85; my thanks to Mathieu Terrier for this reference).

151 *Jadhawāt*, xxxviii. Among his other commentaries on various of Mīr Dāmād's works, Mīr Sayyid Aḥmad ʿAlawī produced a brief commentary on the explicitly lettrist *dubayt* that opens the *Jadhawāt* (1; see his *Sharḥ al-Qabasāt*, 69–70; this is included in full at 131 n. 1), citing the lines again in his seminal commentary on the *Qabasāt* (ibid., 131–2):

Two *ʿayns*, two *ʿayns* not written by any pen,
each of the two *ʿayns* having two *ʿayns* within it.

that Mīr Dāmād's lettrist works enjoyed mainstream status until at least the Qajar period, when Mullā 'Alī Nūrī (d. 1246/1830), the great reviver of Sadrian philosophy, produced glosses on his *Jadhawāt* and *Nibrās* both;¹⁵² significantly, Nūrī also glossed Ibn Turka's *Mafāḥiṣ*, which confirms that the two thinkers' intellectual connection, via lettrism, was seen by some scholars to be obvious until quite recently.¹⁵³ Mīrzā Mahdī Āshtiyānī (d. 1372/1952), a pivotal member of the so-called school of Tehran and teacher to several of the most prominent Iranian philosophers of the 14th/20th century, likewise testifies to his admiration of Mīr Dāmād's oeuvre in general and the *Jadhawāt* in particular.¹⁵⁴ Nor is Mīr Dāmād's legacy restricted to the circles of the scholarly superelite: to this day the Astarabadi sage figures in Iran as preeminent authority on the occult sciences, especially letter magic, with several popular occultist manuals of uncertain provenance circulating under his name in cheap bazaar editions and online.¹⁵⁵ Such texts, of course, are considered too déclassé to merit attention in the literature; yet we have seen that they both accurately reflect Mīr Dāmād's reputation in his own lifetime and represent the most immediate application of his philosophy. Their total exclusion from analysis to date, then, has been driven by reasons more ideological than methodological.

As this preliminary case study of a leading Safavid philosopher suggests, we cannot hope to understand the intellectual and religiopolitical history of Safavid Iran, its reverberations to the present or the nature of its continuity with Mamluk-Timurid-Aqquyunlu precedent and contemporary Persianate and Latinate parallels without understanding the crucial role of occultism generally and lettrism specifically in the construction of a new Safavid imperial culture, and indeed in the transformative – and paradoxically perennialist and Sunnizing – Shi'ization of Iran.¹⁵⁶ Mīr Dāmād and his colleagues were

Two *nūns*, two *nūns* not written by any pen,
each of the two *nūns* having two *nūns* within it.

152 These glosses are included in the critical editions of both works cited above.

153 Melvin-Koushki, "The Quest," 437, 573–74; Rizvi, "Mullā 'Alī Nūrī."

154 *Jadhawāt*, xxxviii–ix; see Nasr, *Islamic Philosophy*, 247–48.

155 These are typically titled only *Mīr Dāmād-i kabīr*, with subtitles proclaiming "Teach yourself the occult sciences and arts (*'ulūm u funūn-i gharība*), including the subjugation, invocation and summoning of jinn, people and angels (*taskhīrāt u khutūmāt u iḥdārāt dar jinn u ins u muwakkal*); incantations for success and good fortune (*ad'iyāt-i [sic] kārgushā'i u bakhtgushā'i*), for seeking children, love, money, provision, the sale of goods, conquest and victory (*ṭalab-i farzand u maḥabbat u rizq u rūzī u furūsh-i matā', fath u pīrūzī*); and the countering of talismans and magic (*bāṭil nimūdan-i ṭilismāt u jādū*). On this grimoire specifically see Doostdar, "Impossible Occultists," 176–78; on the popular vitality of occultist practices in modern Iran generally see idem, *The Iranian Metaphysicals*.

156 It will be recalled that the *Jadhawāt* was specifically commissioned by Shah 'Abbās.

at the forefront of this project, executing it in terms both metaphysical and physical, spiritual and political, lettrist and literalist, *bāṭinī* and *ẓāhirī*.¹⁵⁷ These self-styled gnostic philosopher-mage *mujtahids* (as the very term's etymology intimates) conceived of their role in imperial society to be that of the *mujāhid* (frontier warrior);¹⁵⁸ their theory and practice of magic thus did not merely reflect, but doctrinally regulated, scientifically refined and politically and militarily extended, the popular magical practices so definitive of the early modern era, in the Persianate and Latinate worlds alike.¹⁵⁹ To elide lettrist Neopythagoreanism as a mainstream component of Safavid philosophy is, in sum, to destroy the basis for understanding its theurgic practice – *as science-religion-empire*.

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157 The opening description of Shaykh Bahā’ī in the *Maḥāfil al-mu’minīn* of Muḥammad Shafī’ Ḥusaynī ‘Amīlī Qazwīnī (d. after 1164/1751) is here representative (268): ‘[He] numbered among the occultists while traveling the path of the manifest’ (*dar ṭarīq-i ẓāhir bā ahl-i bāṭin mamsūs*).

158 Terrier, “Mīr Dāmād,” 139.

159 For a comparative analysis of early modern Persianate and Latinate attitudes toward magic see Melvin-Koushki, “*How to Rule the World*.” It bears repeating that the ubiquity of such popular practices was often noted, with scorn, by European visitors to the Safavid realm (see n. 30 above). Sir Thomas Herbert (d. 1682) is here an exception: despite a number of badly informed criticisms of the inveterate Persian addiction to magic and divination, the Englishman’s account of Shiraz, which he visited in 1628, as the occult-scientific capital of Iran and the very birthplace of magic, rather features an extended defense of the same as simple natural philosophy – first espoused in antiquity by the Magi of Iran on the one hand and the Druids of England on the other (*Some Years Travels*, 128–29, 224–25, 303–4). The same association was made by John Milton (d. 1674), who in a speech to Parliament in 1644 further associated Persian occult science with Pythagoras himself (*Areopagitica*, 44): “[T]he school of *Pythagoras* and the *Persian* wisdom took beginnings from the old Philosophy of this Iland.” Its British triumphalism aside, Mīr Dāmād, as a good Persian Pythagorean, would hardly have disagreed with Milton’s equation!

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